



From Diwali snacks to gifting hacks

Turn every impression into festive business growth



Drove **10.8%** GMV growth with **YouTube full-funnel ads**



Achieved **20%** lower cost per search using **YouTube full-funnel ads**



Maximise ROI this festive season



Drive festive business growth



#1

YouTube ad placements in India rank **#1 in attention** versus ad placements on streaming and other online platforms¹



1.98x

YouTube ROI was **1.98x** of linear TV and **1.94x** of OTT platforms²



Maximise ROI
this festive season



Sources:

1. Adelaide IN attention meta analysis commissioned by Google in 2026
2. Commissioned Analytic Edge MMM Meta Analysis 2021-2025

*Some elements edited or created with AI



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THE ECONOMIC TIMES

VOL. 66 NO. 237 | MUMBAI | 18 PAGES | ₹3.00 OR *₹8.00 WITH THE TIMES OF INDIA.
*₹11 WITH THE TIMES OF INDIA AND MUMBAI MIRROR

THURSDAY, 8 OCTOBER 2026

India is miffed over an alleged Ukrainian drone attack on an oil tanker carrying 23 Indians and crude supplies for the country
► Page 4

► Punjab CM Mann's OSD Fails to Appear Before CBI after Summons ► Jharkhand DGP Appointment Violates Apex Court Directions, Centre tells SC: P 2



जब इरादा मेहनत से जुड़ेगा, भारत आगे बढ़ेगा

“असंभव” अक्सर किसी की राय होती है।
सच नहीं।

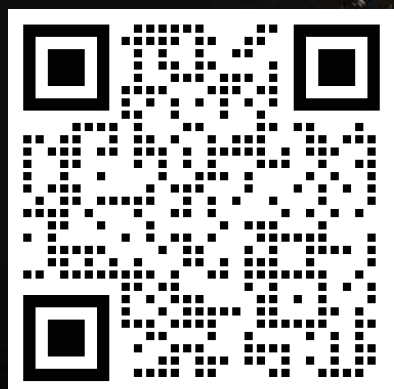
“बहुत दूर है” सिर्फ फ़ासला है।
फ़ैसला नहीं।

“बहुत मुश्किल है” सिर्फ चुनौती है।
मंज़िल नहीं।

कुछ लोग संभावनाएँ देखते नहीं।
उन्हें बनाते हैं।

जैसे धिनिधि।
और ऐसी दो लड़कियाँ, जो अपने इरादों से
भारत को आगे बढ़ा रही हैं।

बजाज फिनसर्व के साथ।



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Dhinidhi Desinghu

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ET Ecommerce Tracker

Returns Comparison (%)

ET Ecommerce Index

ET Ecommerce Profitable Index

ET Ecommerce Non-Profitable Index

Nifty 50

Compiled by ETIG Database

1 Day

1 Month

3 Months

6 Months

Tweet OF THE DAY



AMJAD MASAD

@AMASAD

What's happening in the AI-powered reverse engineering and decompilation is absolutely insane. Pretty soon all software will be de facto open-source. AI is coming for everything and everyone.

Qcomm Sparks a Festive Credit Surge as D2C Cos Hunt for Cash

BRIGHT SPOT Lenders see 30-50% rise in disbursements to quick commerce-focused brands

Ayanti Bera & Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: India's quick commerce boom is showing up in the books of MSME-focused lenders such as Indifi, FlexiLoans and Recur Club, as direct-to-consumer brands and sellers increasingly turn to inventory financing to stock up more to keep dark stores replenished this festive season. The emergence of quick commerce as a major sales channel is driving up D2C brands' working capital needs because it requires them to hold substantially more inventory than traditional ecommerce players, trade insiders said. "Quick commerce is increasing working capital requirements because brands need to put inventory in place before demand picks up," said Akash Valia, cofounder at D2C perfume brand Secret Alchemist, whose working capital requirement went up 35% YoY this festive season for quick commerce. Traditional ecommerce marketplaces can typically support growth for a brand at 1-1.25X inventory levels, Valia said. "However, in quick commerce, substantial growth requires closer to 1.7-2.5X inventory in stock," he added. Working capital demand is particularly visible among low-ticket impulse categories

such as food and snacks, as well as beauty and small household-appliance brands, experts said. "Quick commerce has become a significant part of the sales channel, especially where the order values are lower," said Alok Mittal, cofounder at Indifi, which has seen about 50% year-on-year increase in disbursements to quick commerce-focused sellers. About 25-30% of business for Indifi's borrowers in some categories is now being driven by quick commerce, Mittal said. For D2C-

focused debt platform Recur Club, food and snacking brands are seeing particularly strong dependence on quick commerce. "Quick commerce platforms can account for 50-70% of sales for some food brands in its portfolio, while the share for beauty and personal care (BPC) brands is at around 10-30%," cofounder Eklavya Gupta said. ET reported on September 7 that ecommerce marketplaces and online retailers are expected to sell a record ₹1.5-1.55 lakh crore worth of goods during the 2026 festive season sales, up 25-29% from around ₹1.2 lakh crore in 2025, according to market intelligence firm Datum Intelligence.

TIGHT CALENDAR The compressed 4-month festive calendar is also boosting credit intensity, as MSMEs have to build inventory in a shorter window before sales peak

pected to sell a record ₹1.5-1.55 lakh crore worth of goods during the 2026 festive season sales, up 25-29% from around ₹1.2 lakh crore in 2025, according to market intelligence firm Datum Intelligence.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com

Stocking Up

Quick commerce is expected to account for 16% of festive spending this year

To cater to growing demand, brands are ramping up their working capital borrowing

Lenders like Indifi, FlexiLoans & Recur Club in top focus

MeitY Planning Strict Protocol for Swift Takedown of CSEAM Content

MeitY working with MHA, law ministry on user reporting protocols following SC mandate

Subhayan Chakraborty

New Delhi: The Centre will soon notify a standard procedure to help online users report child sexual exploitation and abuse material (CSEAM) and facilitate its removal, officials told ET. The standard operating procedure (SOP) will be modelled on a similar protocol created earlier to tackle the spread of non-consensual imagery of women online, they said. The National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCCRP) may also create a separate category for reporting CSEAM. Last year in November, the Centre had launched an SOP to curb non-consensual intimate imagery (NCII). This, along with a tighter deadline for removing such content, has facilitated swift removal of NCII. As much as 85% of such content is now being removed by social media intermediaries within two hours of being flagged, officials at the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) said. A similar SOP for CSEAM will be created by next week, they said. "It will spell out protocols for victims, intermediaries and law enforcement agencies to report, remove and prevent the spread of such content, for

which there is zero tolerance," said a MeitY official. To develop the SOP, MeitY is working with the ministries of law and justice, and women and child development, the official said. Officials said the SOP is part of a broader effort to strengthen the legal framework governing individuals' online rights, amid growing concerns over social media harms such as harassment and the sharing of non-consensual intimate images. Last week, the Supreme Court had asked the Centre for a detailed report on CSEAM mitigation. On September 24, the top court had granted the government a final two-week window to submit measures taken to curb CSEAM and address lapses by social media intermediaries. It had also directed the creation of SOPs for both social media companies and online users to report CSEAM to the authorities. Earlier this year, the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights and the National Human

Rights Commission had begun independent enquiries into advertisements of child abuse content on Meta-owned platforms in India. Subsequently, Meta and Google last month announced they will proactively report all CSEAM content detected on their platforms to the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C).

Peril in Full View NCCRP may create a separate category for reporting CSEAM. Move comes after the SC asked Centre for a report on CSEAM mitigation last week.

Govt launched SOP to curb non-consensual intimate imagery (NCII) last year 85% of NCII contents are being removed within 2 hours

Govt Picks CoRover to Build Sovereign Agentic AI Platform

New Delhi: Bengaluru-based agentic generative AI platform provider CoRover has been picked by the Centre to develop a national unified artificial intelligence (AI) assistant and bot platform, the company announced on Wednesday. CoRover will create AI agents and deploy them using CoRover's sovereign AI platform developed in-house, on behalf of the government. The implementation will commence with the Centre's DigiLocker platform potentially within the next 4 months, CoRover founder and CEO Ankush Sabharwal told ET. It will subsequently scale to a couple hundred government departments across the Centre and states, as well as public sector utilities, he said. The tender was released by the National e-Governance Division (NeGD) under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY). — **Our Bureau**

MongoDB Doubling Down on India as Key Global Talent Hub

Firm plans to up hiring in India and expand its capacity, says India VP

Tanya Pandey

New Delhi: Software firm MongoDB will continue expanding its operations in India—its largest market outside the US—with growth expected to hold strong over the next year, India vice president Aamir Sait told ET. The Nasdaq-listed, New York-headquartered company reported \$2.46 billion in full-year revenue for fiscal 2026. Sait said the company plans to continue hiring in India and expand its capacity to tap the opportunity in the market. MongoDB's India business is a significant contributor to its Asia-Pacific revenue. "We have our own hiring plans. We will continue to expand based on the busi-

AAMIR SAIT India VP, MongoDB **AI is not a very large contributor to our revenue today. But the momentum is strong** ness needs," he said, adding that MongoDB will also adjust its capacity in India as there is a lot of untapped opportunity. "India is not only a market for us; it is also a talent pool to build for the world," Sait said. The company expects more areas of product ownership to move to its India engineering team in the coming months. MongoDB does not disclose revenue by individual markets, and Sait declined to provide an India revenue figure or growth rate. But he said he expects the market to continue growing over the next 12 months, with existing customers expanding their use of MongoDB and more enterprises adopting artificial intelligence (AI). AI, however, is still not a significant contributor to MongoDB's revenue. "AI is not a very large contributor to our revenue today," he said. "But the momentum is strong." He expects contribution to increase as enterprises move from experimentation to putting AI applications into production. On the leadership front, former CEO Dev Ittycheria has returned as interim chief after CJ Desai left MongoDB to join Meta, where he will lead its enterprise platform.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com

Tech Buzz

Apple, LG Eye Thermostat & Smart Doorbell



WASHINGTON: Apple's upcoming push into smart home devices will include a doorbell, thermostat and other accessories developed through an unusual partnership with LG Electronics. The products will be part of an ecosystem of devices that work with Apple's new smart home hub, as well as an upgraded HomePod mini and fresh TV set-top box, according to people with knowledge of the matter. The new Apple devices are set to be introduced on October 13. The products developed with South Korea's LG will also include a smart deadbolt lock, indoor security camera, outdoor security camera and floodlight camera, said the people, who asked not to be identified because the undertaking is private. The products will carry the LG branding. — **Bloomberg**

\$730b

Projected combined spending by Alphabet, Amazon, Microsoft & Meta this year

SpaceX Seeks \$40b to Buy Nvidia's Chips



WASHINGTON: Elon Musk's SpaceX is in talks with banks and investors to raise \$40 billion to buy chips from Nvidia, people familiar with the matter said, in what would be among the biggest-ever debt financings for the AI buildout. Pacific Investment Management is one of the investment managers looking at the deal, according to the people, who spoke on condition of anonymity as the talks are private. SpaceX's fundraising discussions are in an early stage and could end without a deal being completed, they said. Musk's AI, satellite and rocket conglomerate is seeking to raise about \$10 billion in bank loans and \$30 billion in investment-grade debt to pay for the chips, the Financial Times reported earlier. — **Bloomberg**

GRIT & GREATNESS Inside the minds of the ETSA winners rewriting India's startup playbook

Wealthtech Groww is Following its Clients Up the Wealth Ladder

ET'S STARTUP OF THE YEAR leans on maturing funnel as young traders turn affluent fast



Groww cofounders Harsh Jain, Lalit Keshre, Ishan Bansal & Neeraj Singh



presents



Nikhil Patwardhan & Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru: Wealthtech platform Groww's revenue mix will continue to evolve as its newer businesses scale up, cofounder and chief executive Lalit Keshre told ET in an interview, citing the rapid growth of its wealth offerings from a small base. Revenue from equity derivatives and stock trading accounted for 68.4% of Groww's total income in the June quarter, down from 75.7% a year earlier, as newer businesses such as margin financing increased their contribution. "It will keep changing," Keshre said of the revenue mix. "We started with very small numbers and they grow very fast, but it takes time for the percentage mix to move. That's fine, we don't mind," he said. "Credit will probably stay stable, because it will compound at a similar pace to the rest of the business. The other wealth pieces are growing very fast." The Bengaluru-based company was adjudged Startup of the Year at The Economic Times Startup Awards 2026 for scaling rapidly while maintaining profitability. Groww went public in November 2025 and has a market capitalisation of about \$13 billion. Groww has joined a list of blue-chip new-age companies including Zomato, Swiggy, Delhivery, Lenskart and Urban Company to have won the award. Founded in 2016 by Keshre, Ishan Bansal, Harsh Jain and Neeraj Jain, Groww began as a direct mutual fund platform before entering stockbro-

million active broking clients, nearly twice as many as its closest rival Zerodha, according to National Stock Exchange data.

EXPANDING CUSTOMER BASE "Five years from now, our existing customer base will be much, much larger," Keshre said. "The beauty of our platform is retention. We acquire customers, keep them happy, and keep offering them more products, so this base will keep getting bigger. Many of these customers are also becoming richer, and our job is to keep helping them."

He linked the expansion to existing customers becoming wealthier and requiring a broader range of investment products. "Many customers who joined us at 27-28 are now 35-38, and they are richer. Wealth is, in some way, proportional to age, so that funnel keeps updating. Over the last three or four years, we have also started seeing affluent customers in their 40s coming onto the platform," he said. Groww's wealth push includes W, a wealth advisory offering, and MF Prime, an artificial intelligence-powered mutual fund advisory product.

It is also expanding its bonds offering and has begun a phased rollout of US stock investing through its GIFT City subsidiary, as ET reported on September 29. The company completed its \$561-crore acquisition of wealthtech platform Fisdom in October 2025, adding expertise and products for affluent customers. These include regular mutual funds, portfolio management services and alternative investment funds. Keshre said the deal brought wealth management capabilities that Groww previously lacked.

SELECTIVE ACQUISITIONS Keshre said Groww will remain selective with inorganic expansion, with decisions based on synergy. "Fisdom was very much about synergy. The wealth DNA was not there in the company, and Fisdom gave us a lot of expertise. The products we are building, like Prime, are built on that expertise. If we see something good, we will consider it, but we are not actively looking to make acquisitions," he said. Wealth remains a smaller contributor for Groww so far. On its July earnings call, Bansal, who is the chief financial officer, put Fisdom and Groww AMC's combined contribution at less than 2%. Groww AMC's assets under management, nevertheless, increased about 140% year-on-year to ₹5,491 crore in June. Groww AMC has also partnered with State Street Global Advisors to develop cross-border investment offerings for Indian customers.

LALIT KESHRE Cofounder & CEO, Groww

Five years from now, our existing customer base will be much, much larger. The beauty of our platform is retention



Ola Electric Fixes ₹1k cr Rights Issue at ₹27/Share

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Two wheeler maker Ola Electric Mobility has finalised the terms of its ₹1,000 crore rights issue, setting the issue price at ₹27 per share. The electric two-wheeler maker will issue 37.03 crore partly paid-up shares under the offer. The company's board approved the terms on Wednesday, a week after it had announced plans to raise up to ₹1,000 crore through a rights issue without finalising the price and other key terms. The record date is October 13. The rights issue will open on October 22 and close on October 30. Shareholders can sell or transfer their rights entitlement in the market



until October 26. Shareholders will pay ₹16.20 per share upfront, while the remaining ₹10.80 will be paid later. The company plans to collect the remaining amount by October 31, 2027, it said in the filings.

Virtual Patients but Real Results: AI Now Rewriting Clinical Trials

Reuters

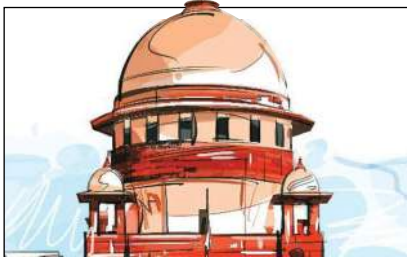
Novartis' experimental del-desiran for a rare type of muscular dystrophy was expected to be a winner, with the Swiss company's CEO predicting annual peak sales of \$5 billion. When a late-stage trial missed its goal last month, shares fell 11%, erasing \$30 billion in market value. AI start-up BioinvestGPT was not surprised. In July, it ran a simulated trial to measure how virtual patients would respond to del-desiran and predicted an insignificant clinical benefit. It and other artificial intelligence

companies say they are working with some drugmakers on virtual trials to boost the odds an experimental medicine will prove safe and effective when used by actual patients in an expensive traditional clinical trial. **Cos say simulations are being used to identify which pharmaceutical programmes are worth moving forward** The global bio-

pharmaceutical industry spends some \$140 billion a year on human clinical testing, but only around 12% of drug candidates are approved by regulators—a rate that has changed little in decades. AI firms say simulations are being used to identify which pharmaceutical programmes are worth moving forward and to assess the value of acquisition targets. As AI tools get better at flagging clinical risks, they say unexpected trial failures may become less frequent. Human clinical trials typically start with small Phase I studies primarily to gauge safety, followed by mid-stage Phase 2 and the large Phase 3 trials required by regulators that also assess efficacy.

Anthropic Gives Cyber Cos Access to Latest AI Models

Anthropic is expanding access to its most advanced AI models, allowing a select group of organisations to test the startup's cutting-edge cyber capabilities in collaboration with the US government. The San Francisco-based company will grant verified organisations access to its most capable models, including Claude Opus 5.5, Claude Sonnet 5.5, Claude Mythos 5.1, and new models moving forward, as per a statement Tuesday. — **Bloomberg**



PURE POLITICS

SC to Examine Plea on Revoking Verdict in CEC Appointment Case

CJI Surya Kant has said the apex court will examine a plea seeking recall of its September 23 split verdict on the constitutional challenge to the 2023 appointment law for the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners. **Raghav Ohri reports. >> 2**

■ **Centre Contests J'khand DGP Appointment in Apex Court >> 2**

■ **New Delhi Miffed as Ukraine Hits Ship with Indian Crew >> 4**

India's Growth Hinges on Efficient Use of Capital, Talent: Stanford's Gill

India is in a "conditionally great" position to sustain growth, but much will depend on how quickly it opens its economy, adopts AI and uses capital, talent and energy efficiently, Indermit Gill, distinguished visiting fellow at Stanford University, tells **Anoushka Sawhney. >> 7**

18% GST Likely on NBFC Services to Banks in Co-lending Arrangements

The GST Council's fitment committee has decided that NBFC services to banks in the co-lending models will be taxed at 18%, with their value determined in the RBI-prescribed manner. **>> 5**

■ **MeitY Planning SOPs to Report Child Abuse Content >> Facing Page**

With JSW, VW to Rev Up India Expansion

 Volkswagen Group is fully rethinking its India strategy —from procurement of parts and production, to launches and dealer network expansion along with its partner-to-be JSW Group, Skoda Auto's acting CEO Holger Peters told employees. **Shally Seth Mohile reports. >> 6**

Duo Win Chemistry Nobel for Solving Molecular 'Mystery'

AROUND THE WORLD >> 13

BURST OF FESTIVITY

QUICK COMMERCE SPARKS CREDIT SURGE AS D2C COS HUNT FOR CASH >> FACING PAGE

Ecommerce may Offer Shorter Sale Periods, Smaller Discounts

BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE >> 6



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RBI SEES HIGHER GROWTH DURING FY, AT 7.1%

Central Bank Raises Policy Rate After Nearly 4 Yrs, a First for Guv

Takes hawkish stance with 5.5% repo rate in response to elevated yields and oil prices

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday expectedly raised its benchmark repo rate by a quarter percentage point to 5.5% in the first such increase since February 2023, joining major global central banks in tightening monetary policy amid steepening bond yields and potentially inflationary transport fuel costs.

The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) also signalled that another rate increase could be on the table, with four of its six members voting to change the policy stance — from 'neutral' to 'calibrated tightening' — even as it raised FY27 growth forecast by

MPC's Crystal Ball

FOR FY27, RBI RAISES...

Growth projection to **7.1%, vs 6.7%** in August Inflation forecast to **5.2, vs 5%** in August

Policy stance changes from 'neutral' to 'calibrated tightening'

 **Rate cuts are off the table in the near term, and policy action can only be a hike or a pause, depending on the evolving conditions** **SANJAY MALHOTRA, Governor, RBI**

Economists expect another **50 bps** hike by end of fiscal year

 Central bank governor says rupee is undervalued

Concerns over El Niño-hit monsoon, rising oil prices

RBI projects oil at **\$98/bbl in H2 of FY27, \$85/bbl in FY28**



40 basis points (bps) to 7.1%, matching the latest upgraded World Bank assessment.

One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.

This is the first rate increase on Governor Sanjay Malhotra's watch after 125 bps of reductions and a 100-bps cut in the cash reserve ratio (CRR) since he took charge in December 2024.

The increase comes amid an

MORE REPORTS >> PAGE 10

unprecedented surge in yields across developed economies, particularly the US, where benchmark bonds used to price financial assets worldwide are facing their worst rout since the global financial crisis.

Yields on the benchmark US 10-year paper leapt earlier

'WILL ENSURE RUPEE IS NOT BEING UNDERVALUED' >> 9

this week to 5.34% - the highest in nearly a quarter century. Persistently high US yields since the subprime crisis have simultaneously narrowed the yield differential with Indian bonds, hampered the local currency to near historic lows against the dollar, and prompted a record \$29-billion foreign-fund withdrawal from local equities so far this year.

'Recalibrating Imperative' >> 10

Retail Loans Will be First to Feel the Pinch

 New property, personal and auto loan takers are set to face higher borrowing costs. MCLR-linked loans, including some MSME and corporate borrowing, will feel the impact later. **>> 9**

Bumper Forex Inflows to Aid Credit Demand

 Banks are expected to face little margin pressure immediately from deposit costs despite rise in the policy rate, with the forex mop-up seen supporting credit demand. **>> 9**

Sept Diesel Shipments Highest in a Year

Soaring margins amid geopolitical disruptions push exports to 620,000 bpd, nearly half sent to Europe

Sanjeev Choudhary

New Delhi: India's diesel exports hit a one-year high in September, driven by record margins, with nearly half the shipments heading to Europe. About 620,000 barrels per day (bpd) of diesel was exported in the month, as per commodity analytics firm Kpler.

Soaring diesel prices and margins significantly influ-

enced export volumes and destinations. "Singapore diesel cracks (profit margins) against Dubai (crude oil) were running above \$60 a barrel in September, a strong incen-

■ **Crude Above \$101 >> 13**

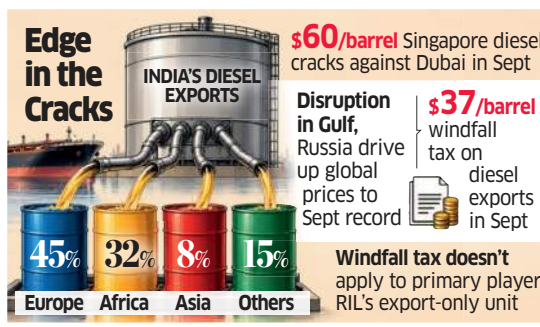
tive for refiners to maximise diesel production and exports," said Nikhil Dubey, lead analyst, refining, at Kpler.

About 280,000 bpd went to Europe in September, nearly

80% higher than in August. There were, however, no diesel shipments to Russia after some flows had been observed in the preceding three months, according to Kpler.

About 200,000 bpd were shipped to customers in Africa, 50,000 bpd to Asia and 40,000 bpd to the Americas. The remaining 50,000 bpd went to unknown destinations.

Diesel Equations Changing >> 12



ET INTERVIEW

ROBERTO ITALIA

CHIEF EXECUTIVE, VERLINVEST

India Offers Adrenaline Rush the West Lacks

Verlinvest plans to deploy €1b in country over the next 5 years

Arijit Barman

Mumbai: An aspirational middle class that does not shy away from spending and understands the importance of education gives India a demographic edge like no other economy, said the executive who manages €2 billion of assets for a few Belgian families that are long-standing shareholders of the largest beer group in the world, AB Inbev.

Their 31-year-old pool of ever-green capital makes Verlinvest one of the largest backers of consumer brands like Vita Coco, Oatly, Juicy Chemistry, Chewy, Epigamia and Wakefit.

"A very substantial proportion of the Indian society is becoming or has the ambition to become middle class. That is emerging from an ability to envision for themselves a future that is going to be brighter than today," Verlinvest CEO Roberto Italia, 60, told ET in an interview. "That prompts their ability and willingness to spend."

Even in the age of artificial intelligence and amid fears of job losses, the young population of India will remain a strategic asset. "This economy is different from the rest of the world for having a fantastic demographic profile," he said.

Pervasive Dynamism >> 12



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CJI AGREES TO LIST PLEA FOR HEARING TODAY

J'khand DGP Appointment Violates Apex Court Directions: Centre in SC

OBJECTION Mishra appointed DGP on Dec 30, 2025, a day before she was due to retire

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The central government on Wednesday petitioned the Supreme Court challenging the appointment of Tadasha Mishra as Jharkhand director general of police, alleging that the state government acted in violation of the apex court's directions governing the appointment of police chiefs.

The plea, filed in the long-running Prakash Singh police reforms case, challenges the legality of the Selection and Appointment of Director General and Inspector General of Police, Jharkhand (Head of the Police Force) Regulation, 2025, under which the appointments were made.

The Centre has sought a direction to Jharkhand to comply with the Supreme Court's directions on DGP appointments and has alternatively sought a declaration that



Supreme Court Directions in Prakash Singh Case

States should appoint DGP from a panel of officers prepared by UPSC based on seniority, service record and experience

Officers must have a stipulated minimum period of residual service

Centre's Charge

Jharkhand framed its 2025 regulation without SC permission, despite directions that states should approach the court if they are seeking to modify the prescribed mechanism

appointments made under the 2025 regulation are illegal. The application takes particular objection to Mishra's appointment on December 30,

2025, a day before she was due to retire. It contends that the state amended its regulations on December 29 to remove the requirement of at least six months of resi-

dual service for appointment as DGP, thereby paving the way for Mishra's appointment.

The Centre has also challenged the earlier appointment of Anurag Gupta as DGP on February 2, 2025. Gupta had around three months of service remaining at the time and retired on April 30, 2025.

The Centre has contended that the state could not selectively rely on the Supreme Court's directions providing a two-year tenure to DGPs while departing from the prescribed procedure for their selection.

A three-member bench headed by CJI Surya Kant agreed to list the Centre's plea for hearing on Thursday.

Under the apex court's directions in the Prakash Singh case, states are required to appoint the DGP from a panel of officers prepared by the Union Public Service Commission on the basis of seniority, service record and experience.

GHUMAN HADN'T BEEN SERVED SUMMONS: OFFICIALS AT PUNJAB CM'S OFFICE

Mann's OSD Fails to Appear Before CBI After Summons

Charges: Graft, bribery, influence-peddling and manipulation of government processes

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann's officer on special duty Rajbir Singh Ghuman did not appear before CBI on Wednesday after being summoned for questioning in connection with an alleged corruption and bribery case. CBI had asked Ghuman to appear before its Sector 30 office in Chandigarh at 2.30 pm on Wednesday. He did not turn up. Officials at the Punjab CM's office said Ghuman had not been served the summons. The development came a day after the agency registered an FIR against Ghuman and five others and conducted searches at eight locations across



CBI action follows an October 5 order of the Punjab and Haryana High Court

Punjab and Chandigarh. The searches included premises linked to Ghuman, his associates and the chief minister's camp office in Chandigarh. The FIR names Ghuman, Nitin Gohal, Jitin Gohal alias Raja, Romi Raja Mahajan, Bir Devinder and RS Nagra, besides unidentified public servants and private persons.

The case relates to allegations of corruption, bribery, influence-peddling and manipulation of government processes, including transfers and pos-

tings of officials, tenders, administrative approvals and access to confidential government documents.

CBI has alleged that the accused were part of a network that sought to influence government decisions and official postings in return for monetary and other benefits. The agency seized laptops, mobile phones and documents during Tuesday's searches and the material is being examined. The action followed an October 5 order of the Punjab and Haryana High Court.

INTERLOCUTORY APPLICATION

Split Verdict on CEC-EC Appointment Law: SC to Examine Plea Seeking Recall

Recall application says justice Sharma's son is standing counsel for ECI before MP high court

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said on Wednesday that the Supreme Court will examine an application seeking recall of its September 23 split verdict on the constitutional challenge to the 2023 law governing the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan mentioned the application before a three-member bench headed by CJI Kant and comprising justices Joydip Bagchi and V Mohana. The counsel informed the bench that the application was an interlocutory application seeking recall of the judgement delivered by a two-judge bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma. "We will examine and then take a call," CJI Kant said.

The bench was informed that another party had filed a curative petition challenging the split verdict. Sankaranarayanan clarified that the curative petition was separate from the interlocutory application and would follow its own course.

The recall application centres on a plea that justice Sharma's son is standing counsel for the Election Commission of India before the Madhya Pradesh High Court. It contends that the association was not disclosed to the

parties during the proceedings before the two-judge bench.

The applicants have stated that the issue is not one of imputing actual bias, motive or lack of good faith to justice Sharma, but whether the circumstances gave rise to a reasonable apprehension concerning impartiality. They contend that had the professional association been disclosed while the matter was being heard, the petitioners could have considered seeking the judge's recusal.

PETITIONER'S POINT

Issue is not of imputing motive... Had pro association been disclosed, petitioners could have considered seeking justice Sharma's recusal

The application specifically seeks recall of justice Sharma's opinion and the common order directing that the matter be placed before a larger bench. It does not seek recall of Justice Datta's opinion.

The September 23 verdict arose from pleas challenging the constitutional validity of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023. The legislation replaced the selection mechanism laid down by SC in its March 2023 Constitution bench judgement in Anoop Baranwal vs Union of India.

FOCUS ON CEC, SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION

Oppn MPs' Bus Protest Ride Shortlived, Leaders Detained

As per earlier decision, INDIA bloc MPs seek appointment with President Murmu

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: INDIA bloc MPs staged their protest march against CEC and SIR for the second consecutive day on Wednesday but this time they mostly travelled on three buses from Janpath to the nearby Windsor Place roundabout after their initial attempt to reach Jantar Mantar to stage a dharna was prevented by the police. After the buses inched through for over two hours



ET

through heavy security deployment and party supporters, police detained many MPs, including Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi, and took them away in vehicles to a nearby police station. They were later released. Protest may take place on Thursday also.

Before they were detained, Gandhi came out of the bus and tried briefly to walk ahead through the gathered crowds of Congress and Youth Congress workers. On her part, Priyanka lay down on the ground, rolled over and said she won't budge from there. After MPs were detained, the day's protest ended. As per their earlier decision, INDIA bloc MPs have sought an appointment with President Droupadi Murmu.

The second day's protest had lesser participation than Tuesday's, with the absence of some leaders, including Akhilesh Yadav and Abhishek Banerjee. It started after Mahi Karjun Kharge hosted MPs for lunch at a Janpath hotel, where they discussed protest plans. There are indications that the lunch diplomacy

FIR IS LIKE A MEDAL FOR ME, SAYS RAHUL GANDHI

'45 FIRs have been registered against me... Want 100 FIRs... Every FIR is like a medal for me'

ANI

cy was used after some allies reportedly complained of Congress' on-umpmanship at Tuesday's joint protest. Hitting out at PM, HM, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat and CEC Kumar, Gandhi told journalists, "My guarantee is that all four of them will be brought to justice. They have attacked the Constitution. All this is their panic reactions. We are not going to stop protesting till Gyanesh Kumar resigns. This is a fight to protect the most sacred thing in the country."

On an FIR filed against him over Tuesday's protest, Gandhi said 45 FIRs have already been registered against him and that he wants 100 FIRs as "Every FIR is like a medal for me".

AKHILESH ON RAHUL FIR

Police has no work except filing FIRs

Samajwadi Party President



Ex-Bengal EC Officials Considering Defamation Suit Against Moitra

Jayatri Nag

Kolkata: Manoj Kumar Agarwal, the current West Bengal chief secretary who was chief electoral officer during the special intensive revision of the state's electoral rolls, said he was seeking legal opinion and considering filing a defamation suit against Trinamool

MP Mahua Moitra.

In a post on X over the weekend, Moitra described Agarwal and former ECI special observer Subrata Gupta as the "2 biggest architects of Bengal SIR" and alleged they had committed "every illegality under the planet".

Agarwal told ET on Wednesday that he was seeking legal opinion and preparing to initiate

defamation proceedings against the MP. Gupta is now an adviser to West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari. Gupta said he was also exploring legal opinions on the issue.

'VOTE CHOR'

In another post on Tuesday, Moitra called the former CEO a "vote chor" and said it was "not defamation when truth is spoken". On Wednesday, she said CEC "was obviously too busy to meet us (Opposition MPs) yesterday — he had to rig two bypolls in Bengal".

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Joint press conference in New Delhi



No Division Between Protesting Students & Oppn: CJP

'ALL FIGHTING FOR ELECTORAL REFORMS' Cockroach Janta Party urges people to join scheduled Saturday agitation

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Cockroach Janta Party and several student organisations came together on Wednesday to call for a joint agitation against CEC Gyanesh Kumar and electoral reforms. CJP has announced a protest at Jantar Mantar, starting on October 10.

"This fight is not going to be easy. I appeal to everyone across the country to join us, book train and flight tickets," CJP co-convenor Saurav Das told media persons here. He added that the protest will continue even after Kumar resigns, until the electoral system is overhauled.

Apart from CJP members, AISA president Neha Bora, and members

of other student organisations such as SFI and AISF were present at the press meet. Backing INDIA bloc, they said the fight was between BJP and those fighting to save democracy.

"There are no divisions. We, the people of India, versus BJP. If we lead this fight unitedly, we will do it effectively. The elected representatives have a duty to take to the streets

to raise people's issues and defend their rights," AISA president Neha Bora told media persons.

This projection of unity comes days after online sparring between CJP and sections aligned with Congress.

Das said that Delhi Police has been informed about their protest on October 10.

ate defamation proceedings against the MP. Gupta is now an adviser to West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari. Gupta said he was also exploring legal opinions on the issue.

Joint press conference in New Delhi



'PASCHIM BANGA WOULD PRESERVE HISTORICAL IDENTITY OF THE STATE'

West Bengal to be Renamed as 'Paschim Banga': State BJP Chief Bhattacharya

Jayatri Nag

Kolkata: West Bengal will be renamed as 'Paschim Banga', West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya said on Wednesday.

Bhattacharya said this is BJP's long-pending demand, adding that the proposal will first be passed in the assembly and then sent to the Centre for approval. He claimed that 'Paschim Banga' would preserve the state's historical identity. Bhattacharya said that names such

as 'Paschim Bangla', 'Bangla' and 'Banga' would not be considered. "Paschim Banga will be the name."

The previous Trinamool Congress government had proposed changing the state's name to 'Bangla'. Former chief minister Mamata

Banerjee had said that the existing name — West Bengal — was lower in alphabetical listings and, hence, she gets to speak last in national meetings. However, the Centre didn't approve the proposal. Recently, Kerala was renamed as 'Keralam'.

CENTRE DIDN'T APPROVE MAMATA'S 'BANGLA' PLAN

Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool govt had proposed changing state's name to 'Bangla', but proposal wasn't approved by Centre



Delhi's Seemapuri Building Collapse: 3 Dead, 8 Injured

NEW DELHI: Three people, including a child and a 21-year-old pregnant woman, were killed and eight injured after a building collapsed in Delhi's Seemapuri area on Wednesday, officials said. Eleven

people were rescued from the debris by evening, of whom eight injured were shifted to the Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital in Tahirpur for treatment, they added. Locals said they could hear the voices of those trapped under the debris. — PTI

PHOTO JUNCTION



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NCP Rift Over Pune MLC Seat Deepens

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: Rumbblings of discontent against the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leadership have again come to the fore after senior leader Praful Patel said on Wednesday that the party was not getting the Pune MLC seat as “demoralising” for the party cadre. The remark is being seen as aimed at NCP national president and Maharashtra deputy chief minister Sunetra Pawar.

“It is demoralising for the party cadres from all those districts, especially Pune,” said Praful Patel, NCP’s national working president during a conversation on Wednesday.

Patel’s comment reflects the heartburn within the NCP after the party did not get the Pune graduate constituency (MLC) seat. Pune is considered an NCP bastion and Patel’s comment reflects the deep resentment within the party on the seat not being allocated to it.

The NCP leader’s comment is significant as it comes after state NCP president Sunil Tatkare had, a day earlier, took aim at the party leadership on the Pune MLC seat not being allocated. “Ideally, the Pune graduate constituency seat should have been

Lakhpadi Didi Scheme Boosts Household Income: IIM Study

Anoushka Sawhney

New Delhi: The government’s Lakhpadi Didi initiative has helped increase household income and savings, expand women-led enterprises and diversify livelihoods, and strengthen women’s role in household and community decision-making, according to an IIM Ahmedabad study.

The average monthly household income of Lakhpadi Didi households increased 61% while savings grew 61.7%, as per the study, a copy of which was seen by ET. In addition, the number of Lakhpadi Didi enterprises increased about 48% over the past one year. The Lakhpadi Didi scheme, launched in 2023, seeks to help women in self-help groups (SHGs) earn a

Sports World Play

VITALS

CHINA OPEN

‘Drained’ Gauff Can’t Rally Past Online Abuse

Beijing: Coco Gauff crashed out of the China Open in the last 16 on Wednesday, suffering a 6-3, 6-3 defeat by Belgium’s Elise Mertens in what the American third seed described as a “draining” few days. Gauff revealed after her victory over Chinese 16-year-old Sun Xinran on Monday that she had received an “insane” amount of racial abuse on social media following a match in which a replayed point sparked an online backlash. Asked what the previous 36 hours had been like, the 22-year-old told a news conference: “It has been kind of draining. I’m not going to lie. I just turn off my phone and move on. There’s nothing you can do.” AP

Today: Smart Basketballs; Tomorrow: Referee?

New York: The NBA will be experimenting with two pieces of technology in the leadup to the season, the league announced earlier this week. Select exhibition games will include a smart basketball that has a Bluetooth sensor in it and can collect data for future use in real-time officiating decisions. The league said the information from the Wilson-developed connected balls will be for research only and not affect calls made during those games. Officials will also use wrist wearables to communicate with the replay centre in designated situations, including replay reviews, scoring changes and clock malfunctions. AP

‘JUST THE BEGINNING’

Arteta Signs New Contract with Arsenal Till 2030

Mikel Arteta vowed “this is only the beginning of what we can achieve together” after signing a new contract with Premier League champions Arsenal until 2030. The Spaniard’s deal had been due to expire at the end of the 2026/27 season but if he sees out his new contract he will have been at the Emirates for more than a decade. The club said in a statement on Wednesday that the new agreement, which was widely expected, “reflects our shared belief that the progress we’ve made and last season’s success is the beginning of a special period in our history”. The manager reacted by saying: “This club is unique, its character and the way it makes you feel, and I have a great sense of privilege that our journey together will continue.” AFP

‘I SWEAR I LIKE TO PLAY FOR LIFE’



Lionel Messi described his retirement from international football as the “saddest day of my career” on Tuesday after playing his final game for Argentina in a 3-0 defeat of Benin.

Messi, who scored a goal and provided two assists in the victory at the Monumental Stadium, took to the field after the win to express gratitude to fans and team-mates as he reflected on his 21-year career with Argentina.

“It was a huge source of pride for me to defend this jersey for more than 20 years,” Messi told the stadium.

“Even in the worst moments we went through and that I had, I never stopped fighting, never stopped being here.”

“Not coming anymore is going to be deeply painful. I swear I’d like to play for the rest of my life, because playing for the Argentina national team is the most beautiful thing that can happen to you.”

Messi said that returning to the Monumental – where Argentina played their first game after winning the 2022 World Cup – was bittersweet.

“Now I’m here on the saddest day of my career, which is the day I have to say goodbye to the national team, goodbye to all

MESSIAH’S WORDS

- “It was a huge source of pride for me to defend this (Argentine) jersey for more than 20 years
- “Even in the worst moments we went through and that I had, I never stopped fighting, never stopped being here”
- “Now I’m here on the saddest day of my career, which is the day I have to say goodbye to the national team”
- “But now I’ll be on that side (with the fans), supporting all the boys. Always united”

India Miffed Over ‘Ukrainian’ Drone Strike on Oil Tanker

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: India is miffed with an alleged Ukrainian drone attack on an oil tanker in Sochi that endangered the lives of over 20 nationals and targeted the vessel that was reportedly carrying crude to India. The tanker, carrying Indian seafarers, was attacked despite Indian proposals for a Ukraine-Russia truce that called for the safety of the seafarers and safe passage of oil and grain. Ukraine had described the Indian proposal as the most comprehensive. Yet, a vessel carrying Indians was targeted, sources pointed out. “We reiterate our call for dialogue and diplomacy to de-escalate tensions and enable early return of peace to the region. **The targeting of commercial shipping and seafarers in the region must end, and free and unimpeded navigation and commerce through the international waterways must be restored at the earliest.**,” MEA said here on Wednesday.

A Liberian-flagged oil tanker, carrying 23 Indian crew members, caught fire off Russia’s Black Sea coast after what the Russian authorities described as an attack by naval drones, with all the crew members rescued. The tanker, identified as ‘Aframax Rio’, was attacked by “naval drones” on Tuesday, triggering a fire near the Russian resort city of Sochi, Russia’s transport ministry said.

India & EU Launch Coalition for Green Shipping Corridor

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India and the European Union (EU) on Wednesday launched an industry coalition for a green shipping corridor.

The initiative will bring companies from Europe and India together to develop cleaner maritime trade routes and accelerate the sector’s transition to low-emission fuels, shipping secretary Vijay Kumar said at the third edition of Sagar Manthan, a global maritime summit. In his message to the Dialogue, Prime Minister Narendra Modi reaffirmed India’s vision of a free, open, secure and rules-based maritime order.

“Let Sagar Manthan 2026 be a platform where ideas become partnerships and partnerships become action. We will see in practice this evening with the launch of the

‘We Will Do It’: Modi’s Call to Gen Z for Viksit Bharat by 2047

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday gave a new slogan to Gen Z — “We will do it” — for achieving the target of making India a developed nation by 2047, undeterred by the challenges. Addressing party workers here at a programme to mark his 25 years of public service, Modi said people should realise how they can contribute to making the country self-reliant, the third-largest economy, a global manufacturing hub and a nation making strides in space technology, among other goals.

Speaking to a charged crowd here, the PM underlined that when he began his journey 25 years ago as chief minister of Gujarat, he had never imagined that such a phase would come in his life. He said this was not an occasion for glorification of a person, but for looking at how far the country had come during this period. He maintained that he had always been an eager learner since school and would continue to have the same mindset in the future. “This day is not just for memories. It is a day for filling our pledges with new energy. This is a day for repeating and reinforcing the promise which says we will do it,” Modi said. With a cheering crowd repeating his words thrice, the Prime Minister said, “We will do it. Viksit Bharat by 2047 — we will do it.”

The crowd further repeated the call for achieving other targets — making India the third-largest economy, Atmanirbhar Bharat, a global manufacturing hub, hosting the Olympics and achieving goals in space technology. “Nobody can stop this march,” Modi said.



PM Narendra Modi meets veteran BJP leader LK Advani at former's residence on Wednesday

25 years of public service is a remarkable milestone in the journey of PM Narendra Modi. India is fortunate to have the right leader, at the right time, in the right place

CHANDRABABU NAIDU
Andhra Pradesh CM

COUNTRY’S PROGRESS

This is not an occasion for glorification of a person, but for looking at how far the country has come during this period: PM

Modi recalled that when he started out as CM, he had not contested an election before. “If I had a penchant for power, I would have jumped into the election arena before, but it was not my nature,” Modi said, claiming that his aim had always been selfless service. Referring to the situation in 2014, when he became PM, Modi said that at that juncture, the world had started saying India “is a gone case”. **From “policy paralysis”, the scenario has transformed completely over the past 12 years, he claimed.**

World Leaders Greet Modi

Tokyo | Kathmandu: Political leaders from various countries across the world, including Japan, Bhutan and the Philippines, on Wednesday extended greetings to PM Narendra Modi on completing 25 years in public office. Japanese PM Sanae Takachi extended her best wishes to Modi and praised his contribution to India’s development and its standing on the international stage.

Bhutanese PM Tshering Tobgay called Modi “an avatar of our times”. Philippine President Bongbong Marcos wished Modi continued success in his service to the people of India. Nepal PM Balendra Shah in a post on X wrote, “Warm congratulations & best wishes to Indian PM @narendramodi on completing 25 years of dedicated public service. Nepal wishes you and your Govt continued success and prosperity in the years ahead.”

Serbian President Aleksandar Vucic in a social media post said India is “blessed” to have Modi. —PTI

25-Year Public Life Milestone a ‘Golden Phase’, says BJP

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The BJP on Wednesday celebrated PM Narendra Modi’s 25 years in public life with a nationwide ‘Seva Jyoti Yatra’, with Union home minister Amit Shah describing the period as a “golden” phase in the country’s democratic history and linking it to welfare, national security and infrastructure development.

“Modi’s 25 years as CM and PM have been marked by measures aimed at poverty alleviation, a secure India, removal of Article 370, ending Naxalism, the construction of the Ram temple and Kashi Vishwanath temple, and the expansion of infrastructure,” Shah said while addressing a gathering in Gurugram. “The 25-year period will be remembered as 25 years of India’s welfare and glory.” BJP president Nitin Nabin, while addressing the ‘Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha’ in Delhi, added the dimension of welfare and social security during Modi’s tenure as CM and PM.



“India has joined the world’s top-five economies in 12 years. Even amid global crises, India’s economy is growing at a rapid pace. This is a testament to the strong decisions taken under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi and the economic strength of New India,” defence minister Rajnath Singh said while addressing a gathering in Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh.

OVER 20 ENGINES TO BE SUPPLIED ANNUALLY FROM NEXT YEAR

Engine Supplies for LCA Fighter Stabilising, GE Ships Four Sets to HAL

Manu Pabby

New Delhi: Engine supplies for the indigenous Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) are stabilising, with US manufacturer GE Aerospace shipping in four new sets last month, with production levels to go up further next year.

In a statement, GE Aerospace said it remains focused on delivering the engines needed for the fighter jets to Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL). The state-owned entity is expecting GE to deliver more than 20 engines annually from 2027. The engine

supplies are vital to delivering LCA Mk1A fighter jets to the Air Force. An order for 99 of the F404 engines was placed by HAL for \$700 million, with deliveries slated to start by 2024. However, due to supply chain issues, the deliveries got significantly delayed, contributing in part to the delay in induction of the LCA Mk1A fighters.

Sources said **penalties have been imposed on GE Aerospace for delays and liquidated damages are being imposed on the delivery of every delayed engine.** An additional \$1 billion order for 113 F404 engines was inked with GE last year for the second batch of LCA Mk1A fighter jets. At the same time, HAL is continuing discussions with the US manufacturer for transfer of technology of the more advanced F414 engines. The next version of the Tejas fighter jet — the LCA Mk2 — is already under prototype production and will be powered by the GE 414 engine which will also be produced in India under a technology transfer deal.

AMID STUDENT PROTESTS CONCERNING HIGHER EDUCATION ISSUES JPC to Reach Out to Youth, Institutions on Education Bill

New Delhi: As the student protests put higher education issues in focus, the Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill 2025 has decided to visit urban centres and hold stakeholder consultations with the youth and higher education institutions to get a deeper understanding of challenges to be addressed.

The panel, headed by BJP MP D Purandeswari, has held consultations in Kolkata, Goa and Bengaluru to understand what students and young people want from higher education institutions and proposed new regulatory framework. According to sources, in Kolkata, the panel interacted with the governments of Arunachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Tripura, Mizoram, Sikkim and premier institutions including IIM Calcutta, IIT Kharagpur,



Nalanda University. In Bengaluru, the panel got views of the state governments of Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu.

A source, who did not wish to be identified, told ET, “The panel will visit more cities to get a better understanding from all premier institutions and align our education system to the jobs market.” The outreach assumes significance as the government seeks to overhaul the regulatory architecture of higher education through the Bill, which proposes replacing the University Grants Commission, All India Council for Technical Education and National Council for Teacher Education with a new umbrella body, the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan. —Nidhi Sharma

Kashmiri Filmmaker Arfat Sheikh Detained by ICE at Dulles Airport

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Kashmiri filmmaker Arfat Sheikh, who has lived in the United States since 2019, was detained by the US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) at Washington Dulles International Airport on September 24.

According to an advocacy campaign seeking his release, Sheikh, 42, was travelling with award-winning author and filmmaker Tara Dorabji to attend an ‘Art as Resistance’ panel at Busboys and Poets in Washington, DC.

He was allegedly surrounded and detained by multiple ICE agents after stepping off a flight at Dulles. Sheikh has a pending immigration application and is authorised to live and work in the United States. According to some of his friends who are demanding his release, he is being held at Caroline Detention Center in Bowling Green, Virginia.

The ‘Free Arfat Sheikh Campaign’ alleged that Sheikh was arrested without a warrant despite presenting his immigration documents. According to the campaign, Sheikh entered the US legally on a student visa in 2019 to pursue graduate studies in film at Georgia State University. He later filed for asylum in 2020 and has a pending immigration application. His debut award-winning feature film, ‘Saffron Kingdom’, explores decades of conflict in Kashmir.

IT Dept Searches Premises Linked to Prime Focus Studios

Mumbai: The Income Tax Department on Wednesday conducted searches at premises linked to Prime Focus Studios in connection with suspected irregularities in foreign remittances, sources said.

Prime Focus Studio wasn’t immediately available for a comment.

The searches are based on actionable information that emerged during the department’s earlier search operation involving Panorama Studios and film producers Kumar Mangat Pathak and Vashu Bhagnani, the sources said.

The department had earlier searched around 12 premises linked to Panorama Studios, Pathak and Vashu Bhagnani over suspected irregularities in certain overseas transactions. —Our Bureau

FESTIVE MOMENTUM
Kalyan Jewellers
Posts 26% Revenue
Growth in Q2, India
Business Shines

Our Bureau

Kolkata: Kalyan Jewellers reported consolidated revenue growth of over 26% in the second quarter of FY27, led by a 27% increase in India operations and a 20% rise in same-store sales. International revenue grew 18%, while lifestyle jewellery brand Candere recorded a 64% jump during the quarter; the company said in its quarterly update.

The India business maintained its momentum despite a high base in the year-ago quarter, when all nine days of Navratri fell within the quarter and drove strong sales. Same-store sales grew about 20% across key markets during the latest quarter.

The company also launched its first regional jewellery brand, Akshaya Thanga Maligai (ATM), in Chennai in August. The brand has seen encouraging traction in its first more than 40 days of operations, with Tamil Nadu's biggest festive season set to begin on October 11. Kalyan plans to open four more ATM showrooms under the franchise model in FY27, with two slated for the current quarter and two in the fourth quarter.

International markets accounted for 11% of consolidated revenue. The Middle East market grew 12%, driven by same-store sales growth.

India Tops Asia-Pacific Branded Residences Market by Value: Study

Mumbai: India has emerged as the largest branded residences market in Asia-Pacific by value, with projects worth around ₹92,000 crore, as developers increasingly target premium homebuyers across major cities and emerging leisure destinations. India accounts for 21% of Asia-Pacific's \$45.3-billion branded residences market by value, despite contributing 15% of the region's units, as per a report by NOESIS Hotel Advisors tracking 38 operational or launched projects across 10 markets, comprising 10,452 homes. India's Branded residence supply increased 3.1 times this year, to 3,181 units from 1,015. —Our Bureau

Fitment Panel Backs 18% GST on
NBFC Services Provided to Banks

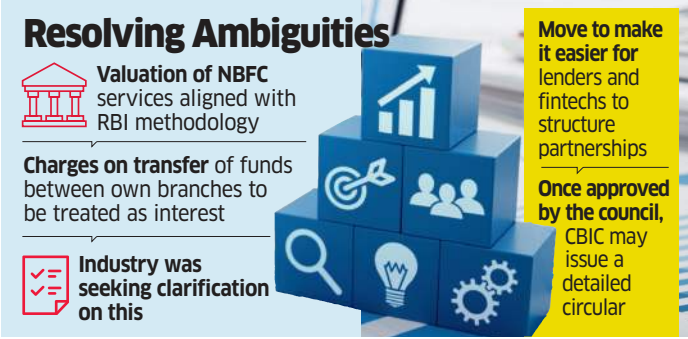
Interest on underlying loan exempted, valuation to be aligned with RBI methodology

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The fitment committee under the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council has decided that services provided by non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) to banks will be taxable at 18% GST, with their value determined as per the methodology prescribed by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), people aware of the development said. The interest on the underlying loan will remain exempt from GST. The 18% levy will apply to the taxable service supplied by the NBFC to the bank under the co-lending arrangement. The committee also decided to align the valuation of the NBFC's service with the methodology prescribed by the RBI.

The council has separately proposed that notional charges recorded when banks transfer funds between their own branches be treated as interest, aligning GST treatment with the substance of the transaction.

This provides a regulatory benchmark for determining the taxable



component and reduces the scope for differing interpretations across lending structures. The move is expected to make it easier for lenders and fintech platforms to structure partnerships without prolonged disputes over valuation.

"Fitment committee suggested this after proper deliberation with the stakeholders, and a separate circular will be issued if the proposal is cleared by the GST Council," an official told ET on condition of anonymity.

The clarification is significant given the litigation and confusion surrounding the taxability of this rapidly expanding lending model. Since co-lending structures involve multiple components, including loan funding, sourcing, credit assessment and servicing, their tax treatment has long been a source of uncertainty for the industry.

The industry raised queries last year on whether an NBFC's income or spread in such arrangements should

be treated as interest, which is exempt, or as consideration for a separate service. The council is scheduled to meet on October 8 to discuss the next wave of reforms.

Under the co-lending model, banks and NBFCs jointly fund loans, with the NBFC generally bringing its customer acquisition and credit assessment capabilities, while the bank provides a larger share of the financing. The arrangement has been particularly important in extending formal credit to segments where banks have traditionally had limited reach.

Currently, interest from the co-lending business is shared in a predefined ratio. For instance, if a co-lender charges a blended interest rate of 16% to a customer, with the bank entitled to receive 10% on its share, the remaining 6% received from the customer on the bank's share of the loan is retained by the sourcing NBFC.

The decision is part of a wider set of measures the government has proposed to the council to resolve long-standing tax ambiguities in the financial services sector.

IATA Opposes Unilateral
Shifting of Mumbai Flights

Our bureau

Mumbai: The International Air Transport Association (IATA) has backed airlines in opposing any unilateral reduction in Mumbai airport capacity, saying any move to shift flights to Navi Mumbai must be based on a demand-capacity assessment and only after consultation with, and agreement from, affected carriers.

The global airline body's comments follow the civil aviation ministry asking Adani Airports to defer a planned transfer of more than a third of Mumbai airport's international departures to the new Navi Mumbai airport during the redevelopment of Terminal 1 and submit a fresh roadmap after re-engaging with airlines and other stakeholders.

IATA said any capacity changes should allow sufficient time for workable transition arrangements that minimise disruption to carriers and passengers. In an email to airlines, IATA said carriers could refer to the Worldwide Airport Slot Guidelines (WASG), including guidance on managing temporary reductions in airport capacity, and the civil aviation ministry's Guidelines for Slot Allocation. The Slot Team pointed to provisions covering demand and capacity analysis, consultation and transparency, as well as capacity reductions after the Initial Submission Deadline or earlier deadlines. It also called for considering alternatives before reductions or transfers, sufficient notice and a suitable implementation period.

IATA said Mumbai airport and Navi Mumbai International Airport should be treated separately for slot-coordination purposes.



ISTOCK

Tata Power, Ocean Sun Tie
Up for Floating Solar Tech

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Tata Power on Wednesday said it has partnered with Norwegian renewable energy technology company Ocean Sun to introduce the latter's innovative membrane-based floating solar technology in India.

The agreement was signed on the sidelines of the second India-EFTA Prosperity Summit, reinforcing the growing India-Norway and India-EFTA partnership in technology, innovation and clean energy, Tata Power said in a statement. The two companies will jointly undertake a 300 kWp floating solar pilot at Tata Power's Mulshi reservoir in Maharashtra. The project will evaluate Ocean Sun's proprietary membrane-based floating solar technology for performance, reliability, cost competitiveness and scalability under Indian conditions, while generating operational insights for potential future deployment.

According to estimates by the National Institute of Solar Energy (NISE), India has more than 102 GWp of floating solar potential, providing a substantial opportunity for the technology to complement ground-



mounted and rooftop solar installations as the country expands its renewable energy ecosystem.

Against this backdrop, technology pilots such as the Mulshi project can help build the technical and commercial evidence required for wider deployment, the company said. The 300 kWp pilot will enable Tata Power to evaluate Ocean Sun's technology against conventional floating solar solutions across key parameters, including energy generation, capacity utilisation factor (CUF), installation methodology and timelines, reliability, operations and maintenance requirements, capital cost and overall commercial viability.

Goyal Holds Talks with Top
US Cos on India Investments

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal held a series of meetings with top US firms in New York, including Blackstone, IBM, The Estée Lauder Companies and Neuberger Berman, and invited them to explore investment opportunities in India, the government said on Wednesday.

Goyal met Blackstone president and COO Jonathan Gray and the firm's international private equity business chairman Prakash Melwani to discuss expanding Blackstone's investments and partnerships in India across key sectors.

Other businesses that Goyal met included Neuberger Berman, where he met chairman and CEO George Walker, and The Estée Lauder Companies, where he met president and CEO Stephane de La Fave-

rie. "They discussed growth opportunities in India, including through increased manufacturing and sourcing, and India's growing beauty and personal care market," the commerce and industry ministry said in a statement.

In his meeting with IBM chairman and CEO Arvind Krishna, discussions focused on further strengthening the company's engagement in India and expanding collaboration in AI, cloud infrastructure, quantum computing and other emerging technologies.

Goyal also met General Atlantic chairman and CEO William E. Ford to discuss opportunities to deepen the company's investment and business engagement with India.

He also met AIA Group non-executive chairman Mark Tucker to discuss opportunities in the insurance and financial services sectors.

"The meetings provided an opportunity to discuss India's growth prospects and investment opportunities across financial services, manufacturing, energy, technology, AI and other sectors, and ways to further strengthen India-US economic and commercial ties," the ministry said. The minister also met senior executives of MetLife.



Air India, SIA Widen Partnership
to Offer More Choice, Flexibility

New Delhi: Air India and Singapore Airlines on Wednesday announced an expansion of their commercial cooperation, offering more flight options to travellers between India and Singapore. The expansion is part of the initiatives under the Commercial Cooperation Framework Agreement signed in January. From October 15, both airlines will offer travellers a wider range of itineraries and flight options through their respective booking channels. —Our Bureau

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Ericsson Bets on Localisation to Deepen its India Footprint

Swedish co reaches out to suppliers to set up manufacturing bases in India

Subhrojit Mallick & Kiran Rathee

New Delhi: Swedish telecommunications equipment supplier Ericsson is actively working with the government to encourage its component suppliers to establish manufacturing bases in India in a bid to increase local value addition, Andres Vicente, CEO, South-East Asia, Oceania and India, Ericsson, told ET.

He said the company has done an assessment of all the components it requires and the availability of those components in India.

“What we have done is to reach out to other suppliers to see if they can analyse how to localise the production in India. We will be more than happy to support them in that journey, and this is where we are cooperating hand in hand with the government,” Vicente said.

However, the final decision to localise rests with the suppliers, he added.

“We are considering India not only as a market but also as a manufacturing hub. We are not only producing from India, but also exporting from India,” Vicente said.

Ericsson is working with Gurugram-based VVDN Technologies to manufacture antennas for export to markets such as Europe.

“They are the latest genera-



We are considering India not only as a market but also as a manufacturing hub
ANDRES VICENTE
CEO, South-East Asia, Oceania & India, Ericsson

market, where the company has R&D offices in Chennai and Bengaluru.

“We have more than 200 professionals working in Bengaluru in ASIC (application-specific integrated circuits) design, and this is a competitive advantage for the company..We are linking this competitive advantage to India, and by bringing these capabilities here, I think that we are making an enormous contribution to creating the full ecosystem of India as a key producer,” the executive added.

Commenting on Vodafone Idea’s plans to boost its network capacity, Vicente said Ericsson has been a loyal partner to the telecom operator in its expansion plans despite the telco’s financial struggles in the recent past.

“I think that the settlement that they did in order to remove the uncertainty around the spectrum fees with the government gives them a predictable scenario where they can have access to funding that will be provided by the banking industry,” Vicente said.

He said Ericsson, which supplies equipment for terrestrial networks, does not see satellite communications as posing a threat, but instead as a complementary technology which can help help extend the connectivity to remote areas.

The company is currently developing standards for telecom radios that make satellites compatible directly with handsets and other devices.

Hotel Deals Nearly Triple in H1, Likely to Cross \$1b by Year-end

India ranks fifth in APAC, with smaller cities accounting for 60% of activity in H1

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: The first half of this calendar year witnessed transactions worth \$493 million in hotel properties in India, nearly three times more than a year earlier, show data from JLL.

The commercial real estate services company has revised its forecast of hotel transactions in calendar 2026 to about \$1.1 billion, up 94% compared with \$567 million in 2025.

India ranked fifth in the Asia-Pacific region in terms of hotel transaction activity in the six-month period ended June 30, said Gaurav Sharma, managing director, Hotels, India and senior director - Hotels Capital Markets, Asia at JLL.

The luxury segment held



GOING UPWARDS
Luxe segment held highest share at 52%, followed by upscale (35%), upper-upscale (12%), and economy (1%) categories

the highest share in first-half transaction volumes at 52%, followed by the upscale (35%), upper-upscale (12%) and economy (1%) categories, show the data.

Tier-II and -III cities dominated in hotel transactions, accounting for approximately 60% of hotel transactions in the first half of calendar

year 2026. Tier-I cities represented 40%.

A senior JLL executive told ET in May that India could see hotel transactions worth nearly \$1 billion this year despite the ongoing geopolitical uncertainties and travel disruptions.

Transactions totalled \$345 million in the first quarter, up from \$98 million a year earlier, according to the data.

“The most active investment markets historically have been Japan, China, Korea, Australia and Singapore, and collectively these markets account for 70-80% of the transactions volume in the region,” Nihat Ercan, CEO of the Hotels and Hospitality Group, Asia Pacific at JLL, told ET in May.

As per JLL, Japan recorded about \$1 billion worth of sales in quarter one of 2026, followed by China (\$724 million) and South Korea (\$471 million). India came in fourth at \$345 million and Australia followed at \$235 million. India accounted for 13% of the quarter-one transaction volume for the region.

As Ports of Call Change, Sharjah Looks to India to Shore Up Biz

HORMUZ HANG-UP

Dilasha Seth

Dubai: With shipping routes through the Strait of Hormuz severely disrupted and access to Jebel Ali constrained, Sharjah is betting on the \$2 billion expansion of Khorfakkan port on the Gulf of Oman to draw Indian manufacturers and logistics companies, targeting \$3 billion in inward investments from India in 2026 and 2027, according to a top official of Sharjah’s investment authority.

Sharjah, the UAE’s third-largest emirate by area after Abu Dhabi and Dubai, expects Indian companies to start setting up their production and export bases there as a gateway to the wider region including Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and Iraq, among other Gulf countries.

“We are looking at around \$1.5

billion of investment from India this year and another \$1.5 billion next year. That represents an increase of around 15% from the previous year,” Mohamed Juma Al Musharrkh, CEO, Sharjah FDI Office (Invest in Sharjah), told ET.

He said that Sharjah’s Khorfakkan Port, which is outside the Strait of Hormuz, is drawing significant interest from companies setting up businesses in the country. “Khorfakkan Port is a gateway to the region and is strategically located for trade with India and other markets. I think this will definitely increase trade between India and the UAE. A lot of Indian companies will start using the UAE and Sharjah as a gateway to the region,” he said. Khorfakkan Commercial Terminal is the only fully commercial terminal in the UAE located outside the Strait of Hormuz.

Invest in Sharjah is the official foreign direct investment (FDI) office operating as part of the Sharjah investment and development authority (Shurooq) to attract global business and drive economic diversification in the emirate. Al Musharrkh noted that with the Khorfakkan port gaining prominence after the regional conflict,

the emirate is drawing significant interest from manufacturers.

“We are getting a lot of enquiries, especially in the manufacturing, logistics and transportation sector. There is huge demand for land next to Khorfakkan. Companies are increasingly interested in industrial land, especially in the locations close to the port,” he said. He added

that increasingly companies are also expanding operations from Dubai and Abu Dhabi to Sharjah due to the Khorfakkan port, which lies outside the affected zone, helping bypass the regional shipping disruptions and offers direct access to major international east-west maritime shipping lanes.

“I wouldn’t say that companies

are shifting from Dubai or Abu Dhabi, but there are some expansions. Companies are expanding within the UAE and choosing to be located closer to the Khorfakkan port,” said Al Musharrkh.

The Khorfakkan Port is undergoing a phased expansion by operator GulfTainer to scale its annual container handling capacity from 3.5 million TEUs to 5 million TEUs, with a long-term strategic target exceeding 10 million TEUs.

One TEU represents the volume of a standard 20-foot long shipping container. It is also developing two new bonded dry ports, the Sajaa Logistics Park and the Al Dhaid Logistics Park.

Al Musharrkh is aiming for investment in sectors like logistics and transportation, manufacturing, hospitality, healthcare, and advanced technology.

Docking Time
Khorfakkan is UAE's only commercial terminal outside Hormuz

Manufacturers seek inland port near Khorfakkan

3.5 million TEUs
represents current annual container capacity

5 million TEUs
is expansion target for capacity

10 million TEUs
remains the long-term capacity ambition

45,000 Indian cos operate across Sharjah's mainland & free zones

\$3.92 billion was bilateral India-Sharjah trade in 2025

(TEU = Twenty-Foot Equivalent Unit)

GEARING UP FOR MONTH-LONG FESTIVE SEASON...

Best Online Deals to have Short Life as Brands Battle Surging Input Costs

Deep discounts likely to last only first 3-4 days from Thursday as weak rupee, high logistics costs weigh

Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: Deep discounts on e-commerce platforms are set to be short-lived this festive season. Electronics, smartphone and fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies plan to offer peak discounts for only the first three to four days starting Thursday, before tapering them off as rising input costs squeeze margins. This marks a shift from previous years, when steep discounts continued for seven to 10 days until the first major festive sale around Navratri, before easing during subsequent sale events leading up to Dhanteras.

The more than a month-long online festive season begins on Friday, with early access for members from Thursday, led by Amazon, Flipkart, Reliance’s JioMart and quick-commerce platforms. “Deep discounts will be li-

A Tapering Effect
17-18% Initial discounts will exceed usual selling prices | 10-12% Discounts will later moderate as promotional intensity declines

MEMORY CHIP COSTS HAVE ROUGHLY TRIPLED SINCE JANUARY

**35-40%**
Smartphone prices have risen sharply since January

**10-15%**
Television prices have also increased during cost pressures

**7-8%**
Edible oil prices increased during the past month

**2-3%**
Wheat and packaging costs have risen recently

imited to a few stocks and a few days. There will be a mix of aggressive price offers for a limited period with limited stock, apart from 17-18% discounts in the first three-four days. This will then come down to 10-12% over the usual selling price,” said Super Plastronics CEO Avneet Singh Marwah.

The company sells televisions under Kodak, Thomson and Blaupunkt brands.

“Raw material inflation is immense

and not everything has been passed on to consumers. So, the scope to offer heavy discounts is extremely limited this year,” Marwah said.

Televisions, smartphones and laptops are bearing the brunt of surging memory chip prices, which have roughly tripled since January as artificial intelligence (AI) data centres drive demand beyond supply. Smartphone prices have increased 35-40% on average since January, while television pri-

ces are up 10-15%, according to industry executives.

The weakening rupee, higher logistics costs and inflation in commodities such as copper, plastic, aluminium, wheat, edible oil and packaging materials have added to cost pressures across consumer goods, from refrigerators, biscuits to soaps.

In smartphones, discounts will be lower than last year, while their duration will depend on demand in the first few days, executives said.

“If there is good pent-up demand in the first three-four days, discounts will definitely come down. Otherwise, brands may offer discounts for an extended period as they don’t want to hold high inventory beyond Diwali,” said Tarun Pat-hak, research director at Counterpoint Research. “Discounts will not just be lower than last year but even compared with the preceding two-three quarters as prices have further gone up.”

Wonderchef managing director Ravi Saxena said online platforms have stopped burning cash on discounts, leaving brands to bear most of the cost. “The first three-four days will have peak discounts of up to 20%, then they will moderate and peak again only during Dhanteras,” he said.

‘LIGHTS ARE GREEN FROM A BIZ POINT OF VIEW’

Pernod Kicks Off ‘Operational’ Changes Ahead of India Listing

Begins legal preparations for transition, asks vendors to update invoices to reflect planned public limited status

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Pernod Ricard India has begun the first operational step towards a potential IPO, asking vendors to reflect its proposed public limited status on invoices, people familiar with the matter said, as the French spirits maker moves ahead with legal preparations for a possible listing of its India business, people in the know said.

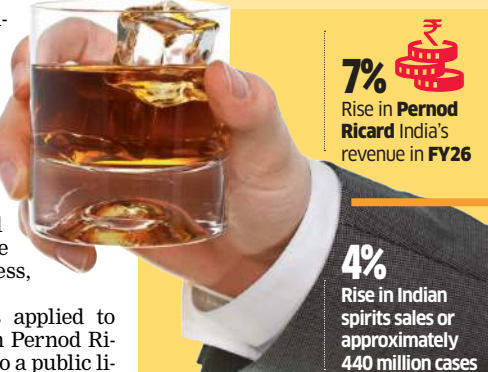
Pernod Ricard India has applied to change its legal status from Pernod Ricard India Private Limited to a public limited company and has begun preparing vendors for the transition, the people said. Pernod has not announced an IPO timetable or appointed advisers for the offering. However, the changes underway suggest preparations are moving from board-level discussions into the company’s operations and supply chain.

The transition could have wider implications for Pernod’s operations be-

Have a Drink
Operational preparations indicate discussions have advanced beyond boardrooms

Legal changes may require updates across state excise systems

Pernod is increasing inventory to minimise potential supply disruptions



7%
Rise in Pernod Ricard India's revenue in FY26

4%
Rise in Indian spirits sales or approximately 440 million cases

cause liquor manufacturing and sales in India are governed by state-specific excise licences, registrations and approvals. Changes to the legal entity can therefore require updates across manufacturing, procurement, invoicing and distribution systems.

Pernod has increased supplies and built

inventory to minimise disruption to the market while the transition takes place, sources familiar with the matter said.

The company is seeking to avoid a repeat of the experience of Bira 91, whose parent B9 Beverages changed its legal status from a private to a public company as part of preparations for a proposed IPO. The transition required changes to licences and registrations across states, disrupting supplies and resulting in inventory write-offs, highlighting the operational risks for alcohol companies when their legal identity changes.

The move follows global CEO Alexandre Ricard’s recent confirmation that the company’s board is discussing an India listing and has started legal preparations to keep the option open.

“It’s not an obvious yes or no,” Ricard told investors, saying the board was evaluating the strategic rationale and potential shareholder value creation. The company was taking “legal preparatory steps” to maintain flexibility around an India IPO, he said.

For the maker of Chivas Regal and Blenders Pride, the preparations come as India becomes an increasingly important growth market for the group.

Pernod Ricard India reported a 7% increase in revenue in FY26. Spirits sales in India rose about 4% to 440 million cases in FY26, compared with 1.6% growth a year earlier.

“All the lights are green from a business point of view,” Ricard said, describing India as a “buoyant market”.

FOCUS ON PARTS PURCHASES, PRODUCTION, DEALER EXPANSION

With JSW by its Side, Volkswagen to Put India Expansion Plans on the Fast Track

Shally Seth Mohile

Mumbai: The Volkswagen Group is set to start a complete overhaul of its India strategy weeks after forging a potential joint venture pact with the Sajjan Jindal JSW Group. This includes parts purchases, vehicle production and launches, and dealer network expansion, Skoda Auto acting CEO Holger Peters told employees of Skoda Auto Volkswagen India (SAVWIPL) at a virtual town hall in September-end. He said the German automotive giant is now approaching the Indian market with renewed confidence and heightened focus.

“We are very excited,” said Peters, alluding to the partnership with JSW, according to one of the employees. The local partner will increase investment, and boost scale and competitiveness much faster, he said, adding the companies are targeting to conclude the JV before mid-2027.

“The whole idea behind the address by Peters and Piyush Arora, MD and CEO, SAVWIPL, was to assuage concerns, allay fears of job cuts and layoffs, and dispel the

**RENEWED CONFIDENCE**

European carmaker, which looks to conclude JV with JSW before mid-2027, is approaching Indian market with renewed confidence

belief that the VW Group will be de-focusing on India after ceding majority control to JSW,” the employee said. SAVWIPL didn’t respond to email queries.

The 51:49 alliance is aimed at improving VW’s competitiveness in India through an expanded product range, deeper localisation and enhanced manufacturing and R&D capabilities. ET reported September 9 that the two sides had signed a non-binding memorandum of understanding (MoU) to initiate exclusive negotiations for the proposed alliance.

VW, which has been holding back on introducing EVs in India for over two years, now plans to introduce two locally assembled battery electric vehicles (BEVs) within two years, with an aim to enhance pro-

fitability across its operations by 2030, said Peters.

JSW and SAVWIPL are also in talks on ways to optimally utilise their existing facilities for the upcoming electric cars, said a person aware of the matter.

“JSW has offered its plants—the one owned by JSW Motors in Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar and the JSW-MG Motor plant in Halol—for the assembly of the electric cars from Skoda Auto,” the person said. “Why invest in setting up an EV line at Skoda Auto facilities in Aurangabad or Pune when it can be done at JSW’s existing plants?”

In all likelihood, JSW Motors will use its existing facility for contract manufacturing of Skoda VW electric cars, the person said.

**SUITS & SAYINGS**

ET’s roundup of the wackiest whispers in corporate corridors

Growth Shot

One of Indian healthcare’s most prominent business families appears to be looking beyond hospitals and wellness for its next prescription for growth. We hear the family is exploring the setting up of a family office that could deploy some of its capital into new-age manufacturing, with electronics and semiconductors among the sectors being considered. Both require deep pockets, patient money and a healthy appetite for risk – attributes the family would appear well placed to bring to the table. After years of building a sizeable presence in healthcare, it may now be looking to broaden the investment canvas. Why should the manufacturing guys have all the fun?

Pet Cover

The honcho of this diversified business family seems to have a soft spot for insurance – just not when it comes to the four-legged kind. The promoter, whose interests span FMCG and personal care and who also owns a stake in an insurance company, is said to have nearly two dozen dogs, besides several other animals. Unsurprisingly, that has caught the eye of pet insurers, who have repeatedly tried to pitch cover for the rather sizeable canine pack. No luck so far. Insurance managers calling on the promoter have sometimes walked away with a policy – but for a car or some other conventional risk. When it comes to the dogs, however, the answer remains a firm no. Talk about knowing which risks you’re willing to take.

Privy to the juicy tips in power corridors or whippers in India Inc? Do share with us at etsuits.sayings@timesofindia.com

Airtel Hikes Monthly Post-paid Tariffs by 3-11%

New Delhi: Bharti Airtel has increased monthly post-paid tariffs in the range of 3-11% effective October 8, and bundled one free five-day international roaming pack per SIM or number each year. Airtel has effectively increased the post-paid tariffs by ₹50 across the majority of its plans. This comes after the company discontinued some popular prepaid plans a few months ago.

The free international roaming pack from Airtel follows a similar offer made by smaller rival Vodafone Idea (Vi) less than two weeks ago. Vi, which offers free roaming for up to three international trips a year, has not increased tariffs.

According to experts, Airtel’s hikes are aimed at monetising 5G, particularly with the company launching its Fastlane service some months back to offer better services to post-paid customers.

Airtel’s entry-level post-paid plan will cost about 11% higher at ₹499 a month compared with ₹449 earlier. —Our Bureau

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AITMANIRBHAR BHARAT

WITH BFSI IDENTIFIED AS CRITICAL INFORMATION INFRASTRUCTURE...

Banks told to Take Quantum Leap

Lenders discussing matter internally, working group under SBI chief looking into it

Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: The government has directed banks to develop a sector-wide quantum transition and adoption strategy, along with an artificial intelligence (AI) resilience framework. This follows the identification of the banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI) sector as critical information infrastructure, said people familiar with the matter.

“Banks are internally discussing the matter, and a working group under the State Bank of India chairman is looking into it,” an executive said on condition of anonymity, adding that other aspects under consideration are frontier AI models and associated risks, including development of a sectoral framework on AI-driven cyber threats.

According to the industry, major concerns in this segment include ‘harvest now, decrypt later’ threats, where cyber adversaries stockpile encrypted banking data for future quantum decryption.

The finance ministry has also

Real Picture

Banks to assess post-quantum vulnerabilities, initiate mitigation measures



MAJOR CONCERNS:

DATA ENCRYPTED today may be vulnerable to HNDL, TNFL attacks

Enterprise systems are interconnected;

CRYPTOGRAPHIC FAILURE in one sector can cascade, creating systemic risk

TRANSITION REQUIRES long-term planning, governance, resources, skilled teams

asked banks to assess post-quantum vulnerabilities and initiate mitigation measures, said an official, who did not wish to be identified. “Each bank can prepare its internal strategy, but there has to be some common industry parameters,” he added.

Earlier, public sector banks were asked to explore quantum-resistant, advanced-level encryption as an additional security layer under the hackathon themes. Under the banks’ reforms agenda Ease9.0, state-run banks are to as-

sess and define a bank-specific approach for setting up a tech stack and infrastructure for generative AI implementation.

In May, the Department of Science & Technology said in a report, titled ‘Quantum-Safe Ecosystem in India’, that adversaries might already be intercepting and storing encrypted data under ‘harvest now, decrypt later’ (HNDL) and ‘trust now, forge later’ (TNFL) campaigns, intending to decrypt it once quantum capabilities mature. “The transition to quantum-safe

security is therefore a matter of strategic foresight, national security, and economic resilience,” it said, noting that by 2027, for critical information infrastructure, relevant ministries and regulators are to establish and maintain their cryptographic asset repositories to enable inventory, lifecycle management, risk assessment and the coordinated migration of cryptographic systems.

Failure to act within the current planning window may result in irreversible compromise of confidential data, erosion of trust in digital governance, exposure of financial systems and forced emergency migration under crisis conditions, it said.

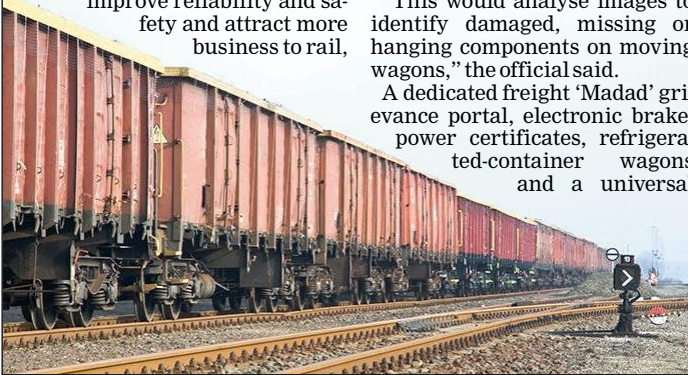
In September, PwC said in a report that banks must begin preparing for post-quantum cryptography migration immediately. The report highlighted that most banking institutions remain in the early stages of quantum preparedness and that boards, chief information security officers and regulators would increasingly treat quantum readiness as a risk management priority.

Rlys Plans Recast of Freight Wagon Ops

THE AIM AI-based defect detection, predictive maintenance and real-time sensors

Twesh Mishra

New Delhi: Indian Railways is planning an overhaul of its freight wagon operations, turning to artificial intelligence-based defect detection, predictive maintenance and real-time sensors to improve reliability and safety and attract more business to rail,



officials said.

“The plan focuses on improving wagon reliability, maintenance quality, freight speeds and customer service are being finalised,” one of the officials said, adding that a field trial of an AI-based system to detect wagon defects across selected zones will begin shortly. “This would analyse images to identify damaged, missing or hanging components on moving wagons,” the official said.

A dedicated freight ‘Madad’ grievance portal, electronic brake-power certificates, refrigerated-container wagons and a universal

wagon for steel products are also planned, the official said.

The portal will create a grievance channel for wagon users and loading or unloading parties. Complaints would flow into the maintenance system for timely action.

“This will ensure concerns of freight customers are addressed in real time,” the official said. “The goal is to make railways a more lucrative commercial transport medium.”

Besides addressing commercial concerns, the national transporter also expects to improve the reliability of its network through predictive maintenance. “The aim is to find emerging defects before components fail,” a second official said, noting that sen-

sor readings and inspection data help maintenance teams identify unusual heat, impact, loading or wear patterns.

Similar machine-vision systems have been used in the Dedicated Freight Corridor. They use line-scan and area-scan cameras to capture undercarriage defects while trains are moving. According to official estimates, the system generated 5,248 confirmed alerts from 115,654 wagons inspected. Officials are considering linking its data with Indian Railways’ freight maintenance and operations platforms. The move aims to improve digital oversight of wagon maintenance.

“The ‘Rake Lens’ gives train examiners a single-screen view of repair dues, alerts and unusual observations. A map-based application also tracks rakes overdue for routine overhaul,” the official said.

Field trial of an AI-based system to detect wagon defects across select zones likely to begin soon

Growth Hinges on Local Reforms, Not Protectionism: Gill

Economist says a lot depends on adopting AI, and using capital, talent & energy efficiently

Anoushka Sawhney

New Delhi: India is in a “conditionally great” position to sustain growth, but turning that opportunity into lasting prosperity will depend less on external conditions and more on how quickly it opens its economy, adopts artificial intelligence and uses capital, talent and energy efficiently, said Indermit Gill, distinguished visiting fellow at Stanford University’s Hoover Institution.

The country has strong domestic consumption, relatively low private-sector debt and favourable demographics, along with rapidly expanding digital and physical infrastructure. But the growth opportunity is conditional: The transition should be driven by domestic reforms rather than protectionism, Gill, a former chief economist and senior vice president for development economics at the World Bank Group, said in an interview with ET in New Delhi.

The global environment may be uncertain, but “the ball is in India’s court”, he said, adding that external factors were only one part of India’s growth challenge. Gill pointed to “inefficient” allocation of capital, talent and energy as major hurdles within the country.

Productive companies need to expand, while unproductive companies need to exit and free up scarce capital, talent and land. India’s difficulty in achieving this has contributed to a corporate sector in which too many firms remain small and too few scale up into globally competitive enterprises, he said.

The same problem applies to talent, as India continues to underuse a large pool of female talent in skilled and well-paid occupations,

said Gill. Barriers ranging from workplace discrimination to concerns about safety reduce the country’s productive capacity, he said. Energy efficiency is another issue. India uses significantly more energy for each unit of economic output than many other economies, according to Gill. Improving efficiency could therefore provide a substantial productivity dividend without requiring a corresponding increase in energy supply.

Restructuring of global supply chains offers an opportunity that India needs to pursue, he said. As companies diversify production away from China or elsewhere, India could emerge as a major alternative destination. Policymakers need to identify companies considering leaving an economy, say Japanese companies exiting China, and aggressively make the case for locating production in India, Gill said.

Vietnam, for example, has demonstrated how an investment strategy combined with improvements in the business environment, can help attract global supply chains, he said. Gill was not worried about Indian companies investing abroad instead of at home. He is more concerned with India’s inability to attract more foreign direct investment. “I’m

perplexed why serious economists add imports to exports while estimating trade openness, but subtract investment outflows from inflows while imputing investment openness,” he said.

India’s employment structure means the potential productivity gains from AI could be greater than the number of workers whose existing jobs are directly threatened by the technology, said Gill.

For India, the focus should therefore be on deploying AI in areas where it can raise productivity.



As cos diversify production away from China or elsewhere, India could emerge as major alternative destination

INDERMIT GILL
Visiting fellow at Stanford University’s Hoover Institution

Annual Pass Takes a Toll, Transactions Dip 5.2% in H1

Bumpy Road

	Volume (m)	Value (₹ cr)
2017-18	127.0	3,352.4
2018-19	254.3	5,760.4
2019-20	582.6	11,294.5
2021-22	1,327.3	22,761.8
2022-23	3,397.1	54,143.9
2023-24	3,840.4	64,809.8
2024-25	4,209.1	72,930.8
2025-26	4,448.9	82,900.6
2026-27*	2,130.8	42,971.8

*April-Sept
Source: NPCI

Yogima Seth

New Delhi: In a first, India’s toll volume fell in the first six months of the current financial year while the rise in toll value moderated significantly from previous years, with experts attributing the trend to the introduction of the annual pass in 2025.

Government data shows toll volume fell 5.2% to 2.13 billion in April-September from 2.25 billion in the year-ago period. Toll revenue rose 6.27% to ₹42,971.82 crore from ₹40,433.53 crore in the same period of 2025-26, a much slower pace of growth than in previous years.

The number of toll transactions in 2025-26 stood at 4.45 billion, up 5.67% from 4.21 billion in the preceding year. Toll revenue generated in 2025-26 was 13.67% higher at ₹82,900.61 crore, compared with ₹72,930.83 crore.

“Last year we registered an increase of 13.7% in toll revenue compared to the preceding year. However, this year we see some slowdown in revenue growth, in the range of 7-8%, because of higher base effect,” a senior government official said.

According to the official, annual pass transactions are not included in the data, resulting in a decline in reported toll transactions. “Going forward we anticipate a pick up in both volume and value of toll collection on the back of a surge in commercial traffic in the festival and wedding months,” the official said.

“The introduction of annual toll passes would have contributed to the reduction in reported toll volumes, while actual road usage remains supported,” said Jagannathan Padmanabhan, senior director and global head, Crisil Intelligence.

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POSTAL BALLOT NOTICE AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION

Members are hereby informed that pursuant to Sections 108, 110 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 (including any statutory modification(s) and/or re-enactment(s), thereof for the time being in force), guidelines prescribed by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (‘MCA’) vide General Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22nd September 2025 and other relevant circulars issued by the MCA from time to time, the Secretarial Standard - 2 on General Meetings issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India, Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and any other applicable laws and regulations, the Company has completed dispatch of the Notice of Postal Ballot along with the Explanatory Statement (‘Notice’) on **Wednesday, 7th October 2026**, through electronic mode only, to all those members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (‘RTA’) and/or Depository Participant(s), and whose names appear in the Register of Members of the Company or Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories, as on **Friday, 2nd October 2026 (‘Cut-off date’)**, seeking approval of the shareholders of the Company through Postal Ballot by way of voting through electronic means, for the following matter:

Type of Resolution	Resolution
Special	Appointment of Mr. Leo Puri (DIN: 01764813) as an Independent Director of the Company, not liable to retire by rotation, to hold office for a term of five consecutive years commencing from 7 th September 2026 to 6 th September 2031

Alternatively, shareholders may register their email address with RTA to ensure the receipt of the Postal Ballot Notice by visiting the link: https://web.in.mfms.mfug.com/EmailReg/Email_Register.html on or before **Monday, 26th October 2026, 5.00 p.m. (IST)** and completing the registration process as specified therein.

The Company has engaged the services of National Securities Depository Limited (‘NSDL’) to provide remote e-Voting facility to its members. The detailed procedure for remote e-Voting forms part of the Notice.

Remote e-Voting schedule

EVEN	143265
Cut-off date for eligibility of remote e-Voting	Friday, 2 nd October 2026
Commencement of remote e-Voting period	9.00 a.m. (IST) on Thursday, 8 th October 2026
Conclusion of remote e-Voting period	5.00 p.m. (IST) on Friday, 6 th November 2026
E-Voting website of NSDL	www.evoting.nsdl.com

Please note that communication of assent or dissent of the members would only take place through the remote e-Voting system. The voting rights of the members shall be in proportion to the shares held by them in paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on Cut-off date.

A person who is not a member as on the Cut-off date should treat this Notice for information purpose only. Once the vote on a resolution is cast, members shall not be allowed to change it subsequently.

The remote e-Voting shall not be allowed beyond 5.00 p.m. (IST) on Friday, 6th November 2026 and the remote e-Voting module shall be disabled by NSDL thereafter.

The Board of Directors of the Company has appointed Mr. Makarand M. Joshi (Membership No.: 5533, COP: 3662), failing him, Ms. Kumudini Bhalerao (Membership No.: 6667, COP: 6690), Partners, Makarand M. Joshi & Co., Practicing Company Secretaries, as the Scrutinizer for conducting the remote e-Voting process in a fair and transparent manner.

The Notice is available on the websites of the Company at www.asianpaints.com, NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com and the Stock Exchanges where the equity shares of the Company are listed, i.e., BSE Limited (‘BSE’) at www.bseindia.com and National Stock Exchange of India Limited (‘NSE’) at www.nseindia.com.

Shareholders holding shares in electronic form and who have not updated their email address or KYC details are requested to register/update the same in their demat account, as per the process advised by their respective Depository Participant. Shareholders holding shares in physical form and who have not updated their email address or KYC details are requested to register/update the same in the prescribed Form ISR-1 with MUFG Intime India Private Limited (formerly Link Intime India Private Limited), RTA. The shareholders can access the relevant forms on the Company’s website at <https://www.asianpaints.com/ShareholderServiceRequest.html>.

For details relating to remote e-Voting, shareholders are requested to refer to the Notice. In case of any queries relating to voting by electronic means, shareholders may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (‘FAQs’) for shareholders and the e-Voting user manual for shareholders available in the download section of <https://www.evoting.nsdl.com/>. For any query/grievances connected with the facility for e-Voting or for any technical assistance, shareholders may call at telephone no.: (022) 4886 7000 or send a request to Ms. Veena Suvama, Assistant Vice President, NSDL, 3rd – 7th Floor, Naman Chambers, Plot C32, G - Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai – 400 051 or send an e-mail to evoting@nsdl.com.

The Scrutinizer will submit his report to the Chairman of the Company, or any person authorised by the Chairman, after the completion of the scrutiny of the e-Voting, and the result of the voting by Postal Ballot will be announced on or before 5.00 p.m. (IST) on Wednesday, 11th November 2026. The declared result, along with the report of the Scrutinizer, shall be placed on the websites of the Company at www.asianpaints.com and NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com immediately after the declaration of the result by the Chairman, or a person authorised by him. The result, along with the report of the Scrutinizer, shall also be immediately forwarded to BSE and NSE and will be displayed on the notice board of the Company at its Registered Office.

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R J JEYAMURUGAN

CFO & COMPANY SECRETARY

Place : Mumbai
Date : 7th October 2026

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RBI Finally Gets Uppity, Takes a Hike

Robust growth gives room to fight inflation

RBI joined the global concert of central banks on Wednesday, raising interest rates by 25 basis points to 5.5% to hold down inflation driven by the Iran energy crisis. India stands out among the major economies entering an interest-rate upcycle for a couple of reasons. One, the economy is expected to grow robustly despite its vulnerability to an imported energy shock. Two, transmission of international energy prices to consumers is incomplete. These will influence RBI's hawkishness over this cycle, despite its low tolerance for growth sacrifice in fighting inflation. The central bank has changed its policy stance from neutral to calibrated tightening, which Sanjay Malhotra explained avoids pre-committing to a series of hikes. The data-driven approach could, however, result in inflexibility if the data turns out to be, well, adverse.

Headline inflation is expected to nudge the 6% outer limit of RBI's policy band in the next 3 quarters. Core inflation, too, has moved past 4% as price pressures broaden. The inflation risk could rise further if the Iran conflict lingers. Keeping a lid on prices at the fuel pump will show up on the fiscal side, adding to the need for monetary contraction. Besides, effects of a deficient monsoon and rise in global plastic prices are yet to play out. Food inflation is not episodic this year and does not permit being looked through in rate-setting decisions.

Credit growth must come off elevated levels for the economy to cool from the latest RBI upward revision. Real interest rates had plunged because of the spike in inflation and RBI's rate cut last December. Indian debt must become attractive to foreign investors as they sell stocks aggressively. The rupee is under pressure on account of India's energy imports as well as capital outflows. A moderately severe interest-rate hiking cycle should address these concerns, too. There is scope for RBI to frontload rate hikes to avoid falling behind the curve, as it did during the previous energy shock brought on by the Ukraine conflict.

Nurturing a Tiger Economy, Literally

Reintroduction of a tigress in West Bengal's Buxa Tiger Reserve earlier this month is a milestone in the effort to restore the viability of India's 15th tiger reserve. But the real test will be making conservation the driver of the region's economic growth and development. Buxa, declared a tiger reserve in 1983, provides ecological connectivity with forests and protected areas in Bhutan and Assam. Its revival is integral to a landscape approach to conservation adopted by National Tiger Conservation Authority.

Relocation of villages in the tiger reserve, ending commercial timber logging, improving grassland and prey base will create an ecosystem that can sustain tiger population. But making Buxa sustainable requires strengthening the Doora's economic landscape. Leveraging tourism for tea and sustainable timber industries, two other prongs of the region's economy, should be the way forward. The return of the tiger should provide a lifeline to the tea industry, by shifting tea from being a basic commodity to a premium, eco-branded experience, like the certified 'Elephant Friendly Tea' initiative on the India-Bhutan border. Integrating tea and tourism could boost income for plantation owners and workers. Making pesticide-free tea cultivation mandatory would make plantations part of buffer zone stabilisation efforts, with apex predators providing protection against rampaging wild boars.

Commercial timber extraction is illegal in tiger reserves, but economic boost from tourism in Buxa can be used to fund high-yield timber plantations beyond the boundaries in transition zones of Alipurduar. As apex predators, tigers are the barometers of a healthy ecosystem. In the Doora, they can emerge as the measure of a sustainable economy.



JUST IN JEST

Trigger warnings before theatrical productions depicting violence – really?

Watch Out! Julius Gets Badly Stabbed

When did violence depicted in fiction — whether body counts in Aditya Dhar's Dhurandhar duology, or a grim tale in Grimm's fairy tale — elicit statutory warnings à la 'Smoking kills'? It turns out, Bill Shakespeare, that Elizabethan Quentin Tarantino, hasn't been spared Sir Wokeness. We hear a Royal Shakespeare Company production of Julius Caesar — not quite a Disney narrative — now comes with trigger warnings for various sensitive issues like on-stage stabbing. What next? A label on a bottle of Evian that says, 'Contains water?' Trigger warnings have migrated from reasonable notices about flashing lights and unusually loud bangs into consumer-protection labels for the imaginative virtue-signaller. Everything must apparently disclose its emotional ingredients before serving. Might as well have FSSAI take over arts and entertainment: 'Julius Caesar — contains 40% grief, traces of betrayal, and one assassination with multiple knife stabs (23, according to Suetonius and Plutarch)'. Cinema will require similar assistance. Jaws: shark warning. Psycho: shower-related unpleasantness. The Godfather: scenes of non-compliant corporate governance. Sholay: dancing on glass. Books fare worse. Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay's story, Mahesh, which depicts grinding poverty and — spoiler alert — the tragic death of a bull, may need a serious emotional safety notice.

This year's physics award rewards patience & collaboration – our research system needs both India's Nobel Kept on Ice?



Somak Raychaudhury

In 1968, Francis Halzen and John Learned proposed something that sounded eccentric. They wanted to turn part of the Antarctic ice sheet into a telescope. It would look not for light but for neutrinos, the shyest particles in the universe.

Every second, some 65 bn of them from the Sun pass unnoticed through your fingernail. This indifference makes them ideal messengers for cosmic information. They carry no charge. So, magnetic fields cannot bend their paths. A high-energy neutrino points straight back to the cosmic accelerator that made it.

This year's Nobel Prize in Physics vindicates that vision. The first sensors went into the South Pole ice in 1992. Results from the prototype, AM-ANDA (Antarctic Muon and Neutrino Detector Array), were disappointing at first, because bubbles in the upper ice scattered the light. But below 1,400 m, the ice proved astonishingly clear.

IceCube Neutrino Observatory reached full size in 2011, with 5,160 football-sized digital optical Monitoring (DOM) sensors on 86 cables, reaching up to 2.45 km deep in the ice. In 2013, it reported the first evidence of neutrinos from far beyond the solar system. It has since seen neutrinos from our own Milky Way, and a likely source in the active galaxy NGC 1068. 'Very few thought it would work, including myself,' Halzen admitted on Tuesday.

So, does the Nobel Prize still capture how such science is done? Only partly. Its rules allow at most three laureates, and no organisations in the sciences. The Nobel Committee chair credits Hal-

zen with leading 'an international team of researchers and engineers'. IceCube rests on hundreds of them.

We saw the same tension in 2017, when three physicists shared the prize for the discovery of gravitational waves, made by over a thousand. Halzen's tenacity and perseverance make him a fitting face for IceCube. But the Nobel now honours the conductor, while the orchestra goes unnamed.

The prize still matters. It's the one week each year when fundamental science leads the news. It also carries a quieter lesson. Today's laureates are rewarded for bets placed a generation ago. Halzen waited 25 yrs between his proposal and discovery.

Could such a bet be made in an Indian university today? Rarely. The only science Nobel for work done in India remains C V Raman's, in 1930 — leaving out Ronald Ross' work on the malarial parasite earlier, both done in Calcutta at a very different time.

India was once at this very frontier of particle physics. In 1965, TIFR physicists recorded some of the world's first atmospheric neutrinos deep in the Kolar Gold Fields. India-based Neutrino Observatory (INO) was approved in 2015. It has since been stalled by local politics, litigation and baseless fears of radiation, while the field has moved on.

Talent is not our problem. Our system is. Most Indian universities were originally built to teach and examine, while research was placed largely in national labs and autonomous institutes, away from students. Faculty buy equipment under rules designed for office supplies, and wait months for sanctioned funds.

A 25-yr programme needs stable money, institutional memory and the freedom to fail. Presently, few of our universities can offer all three

This matters now because national policy is moving firmly towards trans-



The long gaze: IceCube Neutrino Observatory, South Pole

lation. The ₹1 lakh cr Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund, launched in November 2025, mostly finances projects that are nominally market-facing. By July, the Technology Development Board had approved 22 projects worth ₹2,192 cr. This is welcome. India has for decades produced papers that never became products. National R&D spending is only about 0.64% of GDP, and private industry still contributes too little of it.

But discovery and translation are not rivals. They are stages of one pipeline. Translation harvests what discovery plants. IceCube needed hot-water drills that melt km-deep holes, and sensors that run for years without repair. The people it trained carry those skills into industry. The sensible course is to ring-fence a stable share of public research money for curiosity-driven work, judged by peers over long horizons. Funds like RDI should, then, draw in private capital, not crowd out basic science.

Are Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) and NITI Aayog helping? The direction is right, but delivery lags. ANRF's PAIR (Partnerships for Accelerated Innovation and Research) programme links 18 hub institutions with 106 spokes, with up to ₹100 cr per network planned over 5 yrs.

NITI Aayog's recent report on the ease of doing R&D is commendably candid. It cites rigid procurement rules,

Halzen's tenacity and perseverance make him a fitting face for IceCube. But the Nobel now honours the conductor, while the orchestra goes unnamed



The writer is professor of physics, Ashoka University

delayed releases, fragmented approvals and thin fellowships. But diagnosis is not cure. The real test is whether the finance ministry accepts research-specific rules. No scientist should need three committees to buy an instrument. Frontier science is now built by global consortia. IceCube-Gen2 will turn 8 km² of ice into their next instrument. India has earned seats at other multinational tables, including LIGO (Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory)-India, Thirty Meter Telescope (TMT), and Square Kilometer Array (SKA). It should seek one here too, for the sake of our young researchers.

Too few doctoral students registered in Indian universities spend serious time in leading labs abroad. Too few postdocs move between academia and industry. Joint doctorates, funded exchanges and paid industry placements should be routine. The aim is brain circulation, not drain.

Halzen did not work in a secluded institute. He grew up in Belgium, moved to Wisconsin-Madison, a public university in the US, soon after his PhD, and stayed there all his life. The university's research foundation, set up in 1925, was among the first university technology-transfer offices anywhere: discovery, teaching and translation live there under one roof. That is the model India needs.

In Pune, as in several other cities in India over the last decade, we worked to set up a knowledge cluster to bring universities, laboratories, industry and the city together. Universities are the natural connective tissue.

Neutrinos are the most elusive particles we know. Catching them took a scientist willing to wait quarter of a century. Somewhere in India today, there's a young researcher with an equally outlandish idea. We owe her two things: one, patient funding that outlasts a grant cycle; two, a system that does not make her wait 6 mths for a purchase order. Give her both, and

India's next science Nobel may yet be earned at home.

So, How Much More Will It Rise?



Prateek Ancha

RBI's 25 bps rate increase announced on Wednesday is significant. But equally important is the signal that accompanied it. By raising the repo rate to 5.5% and shifting its policy stance from neutral to 'calibrated tightening', MPC effectively signalled that the debate has moved from whether rates should rise to how far they may have to rise.

Immediate trigger is obvious. Elevated oil prices driven by geopolitical tensions in West Asia, a weak monsoon and El Niño-related weather disruptions have worsened India's inflation outlook. RBI now expects inflation to average almost 5.8% over the next 3 quarters.

Inflation rose from 3.4% in March to 4.8% in August. Yet, the increase remains narrowly concentrated. Of the 1.4 percentage-point rise in headline inflation between March and August, food accounted for roughly 72 bps, transport for 40 bps, and restaurant services for another 18 bps. The recent acceleration in inflation is, therefore, still largely a supply-side phenomenon.

What is more concerning is that price pressures are becoming increasingly broad-based. The weighted share of CPI items recording inflation above 4% rose to about 37% in August, suggesting inflation is no longer confined to a handful of volatile categories.

That diffusion matters because central bankers typically become most concerned not when inflation rises but when inflation spreads. Monetary policy cannot produce more crude oil, lower vegetable prices or improve rainfall. What it can do is prevent temporary supply shocks from becoming embedded in wage-setting, inflation expectations and firms' pricing decisions.

Once households and businesses begin to assume that higher inflation will persist, restoring price stability becomes considerably more costly. RBI's decision should, therefore, be viewed as a pre-emptive effort to prevent second-round effects from taking hold rather than as a response to entrenched inflationary pressures.

The case for tighter policy is strengthened by an adverse external configuration. Major central banks have resumed tightening. A world of higher global interest rates leaves India with less room for manoeuvre, particularly when the policy-rate differential with the US is close to its narrowest level in two decades.

Financial markets currently expect 3 additional hikes from the Fed, ECB



Target: inflation

and Bank of Japan over the next year. Indian rate markets are pricing an even more aggressive path, implying around 4 additional rate increases despite today's move. That appears excessive. In our view, this pricing is likely to reverse once the market's view of underlying inflationary pressures begins to change.

Perhaps the most important reason RBI can afford to tighten is that growth remains robust. The economy expanded 7.8% in the June quarter, while high-frequency indicators continue to point to resilient domestic demand. RBI has raised its growth forecast for FY27 from 6.9% to 7.1%.

Growth above 7% provides policymakers with room to act. Historically, RBI tightening cycles have often been interrupted by concerns over growth fragility. That constraint appears considerably less binding today.

In a subtle but important shift, MPC also highlighted strong growth in monetary and credit aggregates as a source

of inflation risk. Previous policy communications largely portrayed inflation as an imported supply shock.

Today's statement acknowledged the possibility that robust domestic demand could amplify those pressures if left unchecked.

A single 25 bps increase is unlikely to materially slow the build-up of inflationary pressures. We should, therefore, focus less on today's hike and more on the change in stance. History suggests that RBI tightening cycles rarely end after a single move. Over the past 3 decades, the central bank has not begun a rate-hike cycle only to enter an extended pause immediately thereafter. The closest parallel is 2018, when the cycle ended after just 2 hikes. In our view, the current hiking cycle may require a cumulative 75 bps of tightening.

India's macroeconomic fundamentals remain comparatively strong. But the inflation landscape no longer resembles that of a year ago. With oil prices elevated, global central banks turning more hawkish and domestic price pressures broadening, policymakers have concluded that preserving credibility requires moving early rather than moving aggressively later.

That is the real significance of today's decision. The calibrated hiking cycle has begun.

The writer is chief economist, Axis Capital

'Emerging Markets' is Obsolete



Swaminathan S Anklesaria Aiyar

Once, the financial world looked simple. Rich countries had developed markets. Developing countries with reasonably sophisticated stock markets were christened 'emerging markets'. Those further behind became 'frontier markets'. This 3-rung ladder was never entirely satisfactory. Today, it is positively misleading.

The term 'emerging markets' was popularised by the International Finance Corporation in the 1980s. It proved a marketing triumph. Fund managers created emerging-market funds and indices like MSCI. Investment banks created emerging-market departments. Investors began treating dozens of radically different countries as one asset class.

Goldman Sachs took packaging to an inspired new level in 2001. Its economist Jim O'Neill coined 'BRIC' for Brazil, Russia, India and China. The catchy acronym became a Wall St joke but, unexpectedly, morphed into a political grouping seeking new global institutions not dominated by the West. What exactly is an emerging market today? Consider Taiwan. It is one of

Asia's richest economies and, through TSMC, dominates production of the world's most advanced semiconductors. Its stock market is large, liquid and technologically sophisticated. Yet, MSCI calls Taiwan an 'emerging market'.

South Korea presents an even greater absurdity. It is a high-income economy boasting Samsung, Hyundai and SK Hynix. Yet, MSCI calls it 'emerging', partly because of foreign-investor accessibility and market practices.

FTSE Russell — an offshoot of London Stock Exchange — disagrees. It calls South Korea 'developed'. So, has South Korea emerged or not? Apparently, that depends on which index provider you ask. If two leading index compilers cannot agree whether one of the world's biggest, most sophisticated markets is developed or emerging, perhaps the problem is not South Korea. Perhaps it's the taxonomy.

Bulgaria joined the EU in 2007 and adopted the euro in January 2026. Yet, FTSE classifies Bulgaria as a frontier market. MSCI classified it even lower, as a 'standalone market'. Lots of subjectivity here.

India has a much lower per-capita income than South Korea or Taiwan. But it has one of the

world's biggest stock markets, sophisticated exchanges, enormous derivatives markets, world-class electronic trading and a vast domestic investor base. All three are put in the same basket as tiny Colombia and Egypt, which MSCI also calls emerging markets.

Investors need a more informative map. For convenience, markets might be grouped into 5 broad clusters:

● **Deep mature markets** Large, liquid and highly accessible — the US, Japan, Britain, Germany, France, Canada and Australia.

● **Large sophisticated markets with significant access or institutional frictions** India, Taiwan, South Korea and China. They have scale, major corporations and sophisticated trading but differ greatly in capital controls and foreign accessibility.

● **Developing liquid markets** Economies like Brazil, Mexico, Indonesia, Thailand, Malaysia and South Africa. They have meaningful liquidity and sound infrastructure but lack the scale and depth of the giants.

● **Small or specialised markets** Countries such as Bahrain, Iceland and Oman. They may be well regulated but are too small or concentrated to compare sensibly with Tokyo, Mumbai or Seoul.

● **Shallow or restricted markets** These include Bangladesh, Pakistan and Sri Lanka, where liquidity, forex restrictions or institutional weaknesses constrain investors. But these 5 categories must not become new tablets handed down from Mount Sinai. That would merely replace one rigid taxonomy with another. Maybe countries should belong to more than one category. Better still, accompany broad categories with a scorecard covering size, free float, turnover, foreign accessibility, currency convertibility, settlement, institutional quality, corporate diversity and concentration.

Taiwan could rank very high on size, liquidity, technology and systemic importance but lower on diversification. South Korea could rank high on sophistication but less well on some accessibility criteria. India could rank extremely high on size, liquidity and trading infrastructure, while retaining capital-account restrictions.

But investors like simplicity, even if that has shortcomings. Not everybody wants to digest 20 indicators before buying an ETF. But simplicity becomes the work of a simplification when differences within a category exceed differences between categories. It is time for change.

The old terminology creates the illusion that markets travel along one financial escalator: frontier today, emerging tomorrow, developed the day after. They don't.

The term 'emerging markets' is obsolete. Wall St needs to come up with a better classification of countries.



Freedom From Debt

DEVENDRARAJ SUTHAR

Human life is like a continuously flowing river, where the present rests upon the foundation laid by the past. We can live our lives today because of the blood, values, hard work, devotion and sacrifices of our ancestors who came before us. Pitru Paksh is an occasion to remember them and express our respect and gratitude.

When we remember our ancestors, we become aware that our achievements, success and knowledge are not entirely the result of our own efforts. In many ways, they also carry the unseen contribution of those ancestors who are no longer physically present.

When a person offers food, water or clothing in the name of his ancestors, he is not merely giving a material object to someone else. More deeply, he breaks the narrow boundaries of selfishness within and opens his heart.

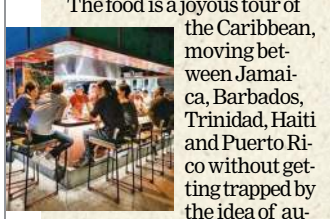
When a soul leaves the physical world and moves into the subtle realm, good intentions, prayers, sacred chants and positive spiritual energy offered by loved ones are traditionally believed to support its journey. Tarpans, therefore, regarded as an expression of remembrance and a prayer for the peace and satisfaction of departed souls.

Pitru Paksh also reminds us of our close relationship with nature and other forms of life. During this period, there is a tradition of feeding crows, cows, dogs, ants and other living beings. This practice reflects the deeper spiritual understanding that the same divine consciousness exists throughout creation.



Kabawa New York

Kabawa doesn't feel like a restaurant. It feels more like being invited into a Caribbean kitchen that happens to have a very good bar; a lively soundtrack and a chef who knows exactly what he wants to say. In Manhattan's East Village, chef Paul Carmichael has turned the former Momofuku Ko space into a warm, tropical-modern room, with the open kitchen and U-shaped counter putting the cooking center stage.



The food is a joyous tour of the Caribbean, moving between Jamaica, Barbados, Trinidad, Haiti and Puerto Rico without getting trapped by the idea of authenticity. The menu is clever: Pepper scallops with sorrel and Scotch bonnet bring heat and brightness; breadfruit toast with octopus is earthy, crisp and deeply satisfying. The mains are equally generous — the goat with spicy scallop Creole is memorable — while the coconut turnover is simply out of this world.

What makes Kabawa special, though, is its lack of fine-dining stiffness. There is precision, certainly, but also music, laughter, generous portions and a sense that everyone is having a good time. What more can one ask from a restaurant?

Chat Room

'Don't Get Cross, Get Even.' He Did

Apropos the news report, 'Jeffrey Archer Passes Away' (Oct 7), Jeffrey Archer was a master storyteller who kept millions of readers spellbound and, many a time, gasping for breath as they turned the pages of his thrillers. His literary journey began in 1976 with Not a Penny More, Not a Penny Less, and fittingly reached its final chapter with Adam & Eve, released on Oct 6, 2026, just a day after his death. This marked the culmination of a remarkable 50-yr writing career during which more than 300 mn copies of his books were sold worldwide. Archer famously said, 'People who survived are storytellers.' He survived numerous troubles and tribulations and repeatedly reinvented himself, eventually becoming one of the world's most celebrated storytellers. His life reads like one of his own novels with unexpected twists, setbacks, comebacks and, above all, an enduring passion for storytelling. His books will continue to captivate and haunt readers forever: *Tharcus S Fernando Chennai*

LOOKING AHEAD Impact on affordable home loans in focus; more rate hikes likely to provide a bigger jolt to market

Your Home Loan EMI Just Went Up

Our Bureau

Mumbai: New home, car and personal loan customers are set to face higher borrowing costs after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday raised its policy rate by 25 basis points to 5.50%. In the mortgage market, demand for affordable homes will be keenly watched due to the lower disposable cash available with price-sensitive buyers.

After the central bank's first rate increase since February 2023, existing home loan borrowers may see either a higher monthly instalment or a longer repayment period when their loan rate resets.

"We do expect that floating home rates will be repriced and higher construction costs will be passed onto the buyers, with mid-segment affordability likely to remain under the scanner," said Lata Pillai, senior MD and head, Capital Markets, India, JLL.

According to her, the pace and extent of further rate hikes are likely to matter more to the overall market than a single 25 bps rate hike. If further rate hikes could be avoided, the demand dent is expected to be minimal.

RBI Monetary Policy

Borrowing Cost
₹50-LAKH HOME LOAN
IMPACT: 20 years tenure, EMI rises about ₹781/month if rate moves from 8% to 8.25%
LOANS EXPOSED TO REPRICING: EBLR loans = 68.2%; MCLR-linked loans = 29.6%

AFFORDABLE HOUSING: Homes priced below ₹50 lakh saw sales fall 14% to 47,660 units in Jan-Sep

₹50 LAKH-₹1 CRORE SEGMENT: Sales fell 5.9% to 69,380 units

MARKET SHARE: Homes below ₹1 crore still account for over 40% of residential sales by volume

"Demand fundamentals remain strong and a robust GDP growth, growing investments and a healthy construction sector are likely to absorb the negative impact," Pillai said. While overall credit climbed more than 19% in the first five months of FY27, RBI data published earlier showed secured retail credit – particularly of homes and borrowings against pledged gold – has exceeded loan demand in other consumer discretionary categories.

Together with corporate loans, retail borrowing is at the vanguard of incremental credit growth in India, where outstanding system-level loans climbed to ₹224 lakh crore at the end of August.

The monetary policy committee

(MPC) voted unanimously for the increase and adopted a stance of "calibrated tightening". RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said rate cuts were off the table for now, leaving a further increase or a pause as the choices at future meetings.

REPRICING RETAIL LOANS

The impact on existing borrowers will depend on the benchmark in their loan agreement. Banks must reset rates on loans linked to an external benchmark at least once every three months.

Continued on >>> Smart Investing



UNIT NEAR RECORD LOW RBI Vows to Lift 'Undervalued' Rupee to its Correct Level

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The Reserve Bank of India on Wednesday said it would ensure that the "undervalued" rupee finds its correct level even as the currency slipped to a five-month low of 96.8450 a dollar.

The currency isn't far from its all-time low of 96.96 to a dollar – hit on May 20 – having lost 7% so far this year. The currency ended at 96.7750, 0.4% down as against the previous close of 96.42. The central bank, which bumped up both FY27 inflation and growth projections, raised the policy rate 25 basis points Wednesday in the first such hardening since February 2023.

96.845
RUPEE AT 5-MTH LOW VS DOLLAR

Governor Sanjay Malhotra said that rupee is undervalued in terms of real effective exchange rate and that the market could be irrational in the short run. "We will ensure the rupee stabilises and finds its correct value. We will support the rupee's orderly movement," Malhotra said at the post-policy interaction.

While higher interest rates strengthen a country's currency because they offer better returns to overseas investors, persistent outflows of foreign capital from Indian markets kept the rupee under pressure.

"It's likely to be a factor of stronger dollar index and withdrawal of debt and equity investments by foreign investors," Bank of Baroda chief economist Madan Sabnavis said.

Traders said that the RBI intervened in the forex market to cap the fall.

Continued on >>> Smart Investing

SEPT 16-30 PROFIT-TAKING, VALUATIONS IN FOCUS

FPIs Again Selling Big, in Oil & Gas, Auto, Financials

Foreign Flows				
OUTFLOWS	Sep 16-30	Sep 1-15	Aug-26	Jan-Jul 26
Financial Services	-6,943	-6,204	10,494	-1,12,149
Oil & Gas	-4,469	-2,385	-1,761	-28,901
Auto	-3,542	-2,670	3,106	-35,449
Telecommunication	-2,423	-991	-4,983	-23,148
Metals & Mining	-2,322	-681	1,807	17,758
INFLOWS				
Consumer Services	1,911	422	8,417	-10,161
Services	1,397	905	1,783	8,494
Textiles	636	10	-293	-316
Construction	381	930	38	-4,802

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) stepped up selling in Indian equities in the second half of September, with financial, oil & gas, auto, telecom and metal stocks bearing the brunt of the outflows. FPIs sold ₹21,745 crore during September 16-30, after selling ₹14,116 crore in the first half of the month.

Financial stocks saw the highest FPI selling at around ₹6,943 crore, compared with ₹6,204 crore in the first half. Oil & gas and auto stocks followed, with selling of ₹4,469 crore and ₹3,542 crore, respectively, against ₹2,385 crore and ₹2,670 crore in the first half.

"The selling reflects a combination of portfolio rebalancing, profit-taking and a greater focus on valuations relative to earnings growth," said Vishad Turakhia, CEO of Equirus Securities. "Financials, which account for a large share of foreign portfolios, tend to see significant selling when overseas investors reduce their India exposure."

Telecom, metal, consumer durables and capital goods were the other sectors that witnessed FPI selling. Telecom stocks have seen some profit-taking after a significant rerating, Turakhia said.

The upcoming Jio Platforms' IPO may also have influenced FPI positioning in the telecom sector, with investors possibly cutting exposure to Bharti Airtel to deploy in Jio, say analysts.

Continued on >>> Smart Investing

OTHER MOMMY

OVER 50 JUMPSCARES
ONE BIG SCREEN EXPERIENCE

PVR * INOX

FCNR Flows Mean No Deposit Worries for Banks

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian banks are expected to face little margin pressure immediately from deposit costs despite Wednesday's rise in the policy rate, with bumper proceeds from the dedicated forex-inflow programs seen supporting credit demand without requiring lenders to pay more to savers.

Instead, banks are expected to benefit from higher lending rates, especially on floating rate loans, as these will automatically reprice tailing the rate hike. Floating-rate loans dominate the asset books at retail-focused lenders.

As much as 54% of floating rate loans

for public sector banks and 91% of floating rate loans by private sector banks are linked to the repo rate, Macquarie Securities said in a report on Wednesday.

During the post-policy press conference, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra said high credit growth in the banking system is already indicative that foreign currency non-resident – bank, or FCNR (B) – deposits are being used by lenders to advance funds to borrowers.

Bank credit growth at 18% currently is higher than the 10% reported a year earlier.

Malhotra said the \$133 billion banks garnered through this scheme require proper underwriting.

"There is surplus liquidity today, but we do not believe this is a very long-term phenomenon because of natural reasons like currency leakage and reserve requirements of banks. Through our various operations – whether spot (rupee) or sell-buy operations which we use – this liquidity will get drained," Malhotra said.

He expects a large amount of the surplus liquidity to be drained within this financial year. "Without getting too much into numbers, ₹3 lakh crore to ₹4 lakh crore is the general currency in circulation leakage. Then with our operations like sell-buy, open market operations

and variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) and spot intervention we do to support the rupee, I do not expect that the liquidity is going to remain in such high surplus for a very long period of time," Malhotra said.

Bankers too expect the liquidity situation to change by the end of December.

"There is little scope for deposit rates and non-repo linked lending rates to move now. In a way, the rate hike today was an adjustment to the market rates which had already moved up. But our expectation is that by the end of December, liquidity will be back to neutral or a small deficit as this large surplus will go away," said Alok Singh, head of treasury, CSB Bank.

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JPMorganChase

Make Growth Happen

THROUGH THE BANKER'S EYE

'No Deal with US may Hurt, but Other Pacts to Help'

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The central bank governor Sanjay Malhotra said that the failure in closing the India-US bilateral trade deal could have a negative impact on the Indian economy, but said trade agreements with other countries could help mitigate the impact.

"The impact depends on to what extent tariffs are going to be applied. So, it's premature to answer. But obviously it will have some negative impact," Malhotra said during the post-monetary policy press conference in response to a query on the impact on the economy if the trade deal with the US fails to materialise. However, India has concluded or implemented a series of trade agreements in recent months, which could help diversify its export markets.



The impact depends on to what extent tariffs are going to be applied. So, it's premature to answer

SANJAY MALHOTRA
Governor, RBI

On October 1, US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer said an India-US trade agreement was not imminent. An interim trade agreement with the US was announced in February 2026, with negotiations continuing since April. Subsequently, after finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman at New Delhi on October 5 said India-US bilateral trade discussions had "reached a plateau", beyond which further concessions would be difficult.

India has signed trade agreements with the UK and New Zealand, while several others are in the pipeline. Around 10 trade agreements are under discussion, including new negotiations with the Eurasian Economic Union, Peru, Chile, Israel, Canada and Maldives. Existing agreements such as the India-Korea CEPA and India-Sri Lanka ETCA are also being upgraded.

Short Takes

Interoperability Enabled for Account Aggregators

MUMBAI The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has introduced interoperability among account aggregators (AAs), a move that could make it easier to share their financial information with various financial institutions, including banks, NPS fund managers, insurance companies and mutual funds. Also, depositories regulated by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) are being facilitated to include information on bank deposit accounts in their Consolidated Account Statement (CAS) through the NBFC-AAs, RBI said, as this will enable demat account holders to view information on their demat account holdings and bank deposit accounts in one place in the CAS.

Tech Committee Planned to Address Fin Market Issues

MUMBAI RBI has decided to set up a technical

'A few percentage points here and there should not matter much for overall scheme of things' Credit Offtake could Moderate, but won't be a Drag on Growth

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) expects bank credit growth to moderate from its current pace of about 19% as Wednesday's 25-basis-point repo rate increase feeds through to borrowing costs. It said the slowdown should still leave lending strong enough to support economic growth.

"Credit growth has been at an all-time high of 19%. I think it will continue to be strong. A few percentage points here and there should not matter too much in the overall scheme of things. It will continue to support growth," Governor Sanjay Malhotra told reporters after the policy announcement.

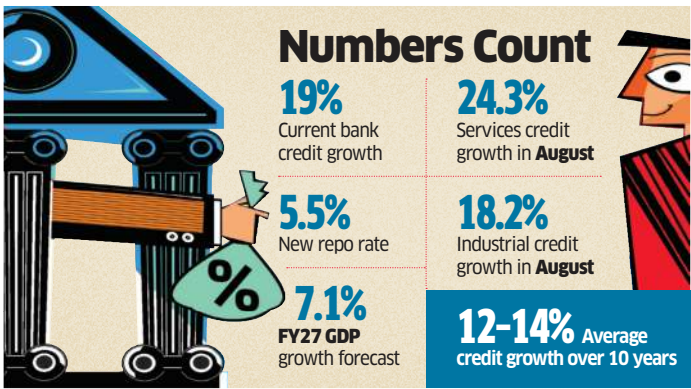
The central bank on Wednesday also raised GDP growth projections

for FY27 by 40 basis points to 7.1%, matching the latest estimates of the World Bank while citing resilient consumption and robust investment. The RBI also raised the inflation projections by 20 basis points, and increased the repo rate to 5.5%.

Higher rates could temper demand for new loans, though the effect will take time to work through the banking system. The RBI also raised its FY27 economic growth forecast to 7.1%, citing resilient consumption and investment.

Deputy Governor S Janakiraman said any slowdown should be viewed against the long-term trend. "If you take a long-term average of 10 years, it is seen in the range of 12-14%, which is very sustainable and very supportive of growth," he said.

"As these rates transmit, it typically takes about a couple of qu-



arters for transmission to materialise. Some moderation will occur relating to demand as well as rates. But moderation from 18-20% is not bad and will be adequate enough to support growth," Janakiraman said.

Non-food bank credit grew 18.8% year-on-year in the fortnight en-

ded August 31, against 10.2% a year earlier, RBI data showed. Lending to the services sector rose 24.3%, up from 10.3%, supported by credit to non-banking finance companies, trade, professional services and commercial real estate. Industrial credit grew 18.2%, compared with 7% a year earlier.

Forex Reserves Down \$50 billion Over a Month

Our Bureau

Mumbai: India's foreign exchange reserves have shrunk by \$50 billion in the last one month after the special scheme to draw dollar deposits stopped. The central bank continues to sell dollars in the spot market to prevent the rupee from retreating sharply.

Reserves have fallen to \$734.6 billion in the week ended October 2, the fourth consecutive week of decline, and down from a recent peak of \$785.71 billion reported on September 4, a footnote to Governor Sanjay Malhotra's monetary policy statement showed.

The latest reserves data were published earlier than the scheduled date of October 9. Dollar sales on behalf of the central bank in the spot market are aimed at bolstering the rupee. Furthermore, the sell/buy foreign exchange swaps through which the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) sells dollars (and buys rupees) in the spot market, with a contract to buy them back at a future date are also being used to support the rupee.



Central bank continues to sell dollars in the spot market to prevent the rupee from retreating sharply

WEIGHING PROS & CONS Central bank to form a fresh opinion after studying whether NBFCs offering such credit can be a systemic risk Directive on NBFC Revolving Credit Products Likely Soon

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday said revolving credit products currently offered by non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) were never approved by the regulator, but proposed changes that seek to curb the practice are still under consideration.

Separately, surplus liquidity generated in the banking system is also not expected to hamper the asset quality of NBFCs, Malhotra said in the post policy press conference.

"The draft framework (on revolving credit) is a clarification. NBFCs were never allowed to offer revolver credit. NBFCs have been given directions against such practice in past RBI inspections," Malhotra said. "Now, due to emerging technology, NBFCs are offering term loans as revolving credit. We have received a lot of feedback from stakeholders; we are studying it. We will form a fresh opinion on this issue, and we will issue final instructions. We must consider if this can lead to a systemic risk in

The Door is Open

Revolving credit have a maximum limit which borrowers can repay and use anytime

Draft norms released in Aug said that NBFCs may only be permitted to offer term loans

NBFCs says a blanket ban will constrain access to finance for MSMEs and individuals

RBI says will review all feedback before taking final decision

this issue." On August 6, the RBI issued draft norms that proposed that

consultative committee to seek views from market participants on policy and operational issues across key financial markets, as the central bank looks to strengthen its engagement with participants amid rapid changes in financial market infrastructure. The committee will cover the money market, government securities market and foreign exchange market, along with derivatives linked to these markets. It will also examine issues relating to the infrastructure supporting these markets.

UPI Volumes Seen Holding Firm after MDR Introduction

MUMBAI RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said he does not expect the introduction of a merchant discount rate (MDR) on select UPI transactions to materially affect volumes. "I don't see any drop in volumes, and I don't think that a small fee will have a major impact on volumes," he said.

Under the National Payments Corporation of



remain outside the MDR framework, limiting the ecosystem's overall revenue pool.

New FEMA Rules Exempt Individuals from Reporting

MUMBAI The Reserve Bank of India has clarified that individuals will not be required to report transactions under the new FEMA rules. The central bank is expected to issue a set of FAQs shortly to address compliance concerns.

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said individuals making routine overseas payments – such as

subscriptions to television channels, apps, journals or newspapers – or receiving payments for providing services abroad, including tutoring or small software-related work, would not be required to report such transactions. For exporters, Malhotra said smaller transactions of up to ₹10 lakh per bill can be reported through a self-declaration instead of uploading invoices and other supporting documents. "Up to ₹10 lakh per bill a self-declaration will suffice," he said, adding that the alternative was introduced to ease concerns over documentation requirements.

MPC Passed the Shift in Policy Stance in 4-2 Vote

MUMBAI Two members of the six-member Monetary Policy Committee dissented on the decision to shift its stance from neutral to calibrated tightening, which passed by a 4-2 majority. The vote to raise the repo rate was unanimous. RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said the new stance ruled out near-term rate cuts, leaving a further hike or a pause as the options at future meetings, depending on how inflation and growth evolve. —Our Bureau

Home Loan EMI Just Went Up

From ET Markets Page 1

A repo-linked home loan could therefore become more expensive at its next reset if the bank passes on the full increase. Fixed-rate loans will not be repriced because of Wednesday's decision.

The exposure is substantial: external benchmark-linked loans accounted for 68.2% of banks' outstanding floating-rate rupee loans at the end of June, according to the latest RBI data. Loans linked to banks' marginal cost of funds-based lending rate, or MCLR, accounted for another 29.6%.

For illustration, the EMI on a ₹50

lakh home loan with 20 years remaining would rise by about ₹781 a month, from ₹41,822 to ₹42,603, if its rate increased from 8% to 8.25% and the repayment period stayed unchanged. Borrowers may instead be offered an extension of the loan tenure, which would keep the EMI steady but increase the total interest paid. State Bank of India currently advertises home loans starting at 7.25% a year. The rate an individual borrower pays, and when it changes, will depend on the loan's terms and the bank's subsequent rate revision. The lender is expected to review its rate for new borrowers on October 15.

'Undervalued' Rupee

From ET Markets Page 1

RBI has likely conducted dollar-rupee sell-buy swaps to absorb surplus liquidity from the inter-bank market, pushing the one-year forward up to 3.82%, its highest in six months. The three-month forward premium rose to 4.95% while the 6-month premium rose to 4.4%. "Corporates were seen buying forward in panic," forex market consultant KN Dey said. "It's also rare for the rupee to sharply weaken on a day when the RBI tightens policy rate," he added.

FPIs Selling Big

From ET Markets Page 1

FPIs were buyers to the tune of ₹1,911 crore in consumer services stocks and ₹1,397 crore in services during the second half of September, compared with ₹422 crore and ₹905 crore, respectively, in the first half. "While services and other sectors offer earnings visibility, services firms earn in global markets. Hence, money has rotated to these sectors," said Manish Bhandari, founder, CEO & portfolio manager, Vallum Capital.

APPLIES TO PUBLIC ISSUES AND PVT PLACEMENT

Sebi Unveils Six-Tier Credit Risk-o-Meter for Debt Securities

Move aims to make credit risk easier for investors to assess before investing

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) Wednesday introduced a mandatory colour-coded credit risk-o-meter for debt securities in a move aimed at making credit risk easier for potential investors.

The meter will translate Sebi's existing credit rating framework into six colour-coded risk categories, ranging from "lowest credit risk" for AAA-rated securities to "high to very high risk of default" for securities rated B+ to D. The categories in between include very low, low, moderate credit risk and moderate risk of default.

The new disclosure mechanism would have to be included in offer documents, abridged prospectus, private placement memorandums,

advertisements and the web and mobile channels of online bond platform providers (OBPPs).

The capital-markets regulator said the framework would apply to all listed and proposed to be listed non-convertible securities, commercial papers, securitised debt instruments, security receipts and structured debt or market linked debentures, irrespective of whether they are issued through a public issue or private placement.

Issuers and OBPPs would also have to disclose the name of the credit rating agency and the actual rating below the meter.

For unsecured debt instruments, the word "unsecured" must be displayed in bold red text. Where a security carries ratings from multiple agencies, the meter will reflect the lowest rating.

For securities where the rating agency has classified the issuer as "Issuer Not Cooperating", the meter would specifically indicate the status. Sebi has also prescribed separate disclosures for short-term debt instruments.



Tech Picks

VAISHNAVI JAGTAP

Senior Research Analyst, Technical

Axis Securities

JAMNAAUTO

Multiple resistance" breakout at 148 levels, huge rising volumes. Above the 20, 50 and 200-day SMAs.

LAST CLOSE

₹152

STOP LOSS

₹144

BBOX

daily "Horizontal Consolidation Zone" breakout at 853 levels, rising volumes, daily "Band Bollinger" buy signal.

LAST CLOSE

₹888

STOP LOSS

₹840

GPPL

daily higher tops and bottoms formation, with huge rising volumes. Daily "Band Bollinger" buy signal

LAST CLOSE

₹173

STOP LOSS

₹168

F&O Strategy

JUBLFOOD FUTURES (27 OCTOBER EXPIRY)

JUBLFOOD has witnessed short covering, with a nearly 3% gain and 4% provisional OI unwinding.

LAST CLOSE

₹464

STOP LOSS

₹450

POLYCAB FUTURE (27 OCTOBER EXPIRY)

POLYCAB confirms a long build-up, gaining 2.1% with 5% provisional OI addition.

LAST CLOSE

₹8,320

STOP LOSS

₹8,100

UPBEAT GUIDANCE

PCBL Set to Benefit as Carbon Black Supply Stays Tight

Sachin Kumar

ET Intelligence Group: Shares of PCBL Chemical, a manufacturer of carbon black and specialty chemicals, have risen 25% over the past six months, as investors bet on higher realisations amid tighter carbon-black supply, improving export prospects and a recovery in earnings.

Pricing of carbon black, which accounts for around 80% of the company's revenue, is expected to strengthen as disruptions at Russian refineries tighten supplies. Tighter global supply is also expected to help PCBL to expand exports to the US and Europe. The stock trades at price-earnings (P/E) multiple of 48.7 compared with the three and five-year averages of 34.5 and 25 respectively, implying a premium for the expected strong future earnings.

PCBL had diverted some export volumes to the domestic market in the first quarter, where value per tonne was higher, as elevated and erratic freight costs made overseas sales less attractive. The shift was also supported by a more favourable domestic pricing environment, as lower Russian supplies and higher-priced Chinese imports reduced the pressure from low-cost imports.

Indian carbon black suppliers face lower tariffs in the US than competing Asian and Middle Eastern suppliers. Higher duties on China are pushing US customers to diversify sourcing. The company's management expects this to create a structural opportunity to gain market share in Europe, the US and other premium markets.

The company now expects freight conditions and tariff advantages to improve, with higher export volumes from September quarter onwards, particularly in the US and sub-

Healthy Show

PCBL Chemical's June Qtr Performance

	Jun'26	Jun'25	YoY % Chg
Revenue	2,474	2,114	17.0
Ebitda	400	325	23.1
Ebitda Margin %	16	15	100 bps
Net Profit	155	94	64.9

Figures in ₹ crore; Bps: basis points (100 bps=One percentage point); Ebitda: Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation and Amortisation



Source: Company data, ETIG

sequently Europe. It is also focusing on higher-value products, which should support operating profit before depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda). PCBL expects its cost-optimisation programme, covering feedstock diversification, procurement and efficiency improvements, to generate ₹200-250 crore of savings over the next four to six quarters. This would provide an additional lift to profitability even without a commensurate increase in revenue.

The management has retained the guidance of a 14-15% improvement in average carbon-black Ebitda per tonne to ₹16,500-17,000 for FY27. PL Capital noted in report that this outlook may prove conservative if Russian carbon black supply continues to contract and global capacities remain offline. It expects Ebitda margin to expand to 14.1% in FY28 from 12.7% in FY26. The brokerage has upgraded the stock to 'Buy' from 'Accumulate', valuing it at 25 times FY28E earnings per share and has revised the price target to ₹391 from ₹388 earlier. The stock closed 2% higher at ₹326.9 on the BSE on Wednesday.

UTTAR PRADESH: INDIA'S NEW DEFENCE MANUFACTURING POWERHOUSE

Uttar Pradesh's Defence Industrial Corridor is strengthening the state's role in India's growing defence manufacturing landscape. By bringing together major manufacturers, MSMEs, technology providers and skilled talent, the corridor is fostering indigenous production, innovation and stronger domestic supply chains. As India works to reduce dependence on defence imports, the corridor will help Uttar Pradesh emerge as a key hub

for manufacturing advanced defence equipment, components and solutions. With sustained investment, technology adoption, skill development and private-sector participation, the Defence Industrial Corridor can help Uttar Pradesh evolve from a large industrial state into a focal point for India's growing defence manufacturing ecosystem, supporting the nation's long-term vision of greater self-reliance, technological capability and global competitiveness in defence.



REGULATORY REFORMS

Under the 'Uttar Pradesh Ease of Doing Business (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2025', reforms were made in 10 state laws and 39 provisions across 10 departments decriminalised



Uttar Pradesh Defence Industrial Corridor (UPDIC)

- With the objective of making India self-reliant in the field of defence production, one of the two Defence Industrial Corridors being developed in the country is being established in Uttar Pradesh
- Approximately 2095.1 hectares of land has been acquired for developing a total of 06 nodes in Jhansi, Chitrakoot, Lucknow, Aligarh, Agra, and Kanpur
- Under the Defence Corridor project, 217

MoUs have been signed so far. Against the signed MoUs, investment of ₹39,804 crore and direct employment for 60,332 people are estimated

- Major establishments include the integration and testing facility of BrahMos Aerospace in the Lucknow node and a unit of Bharat Dynamics Limited in the Jhansi node
- A total of 1155.3 hectares of land has been allotted to 67 industries, which is expected to generate investment of ₹13,905 crore and direct employment for 16,129 personnel
- Out of the industrial units allotted so far, 9 units have already started production



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UP Aerospace & Defence Unit and Employment Promotion Policy - 2024



The Uttar Pradesh Defence & Aerospace Policy is designed to strengthen the state's position as a competitive destination for defence and aerospace manufacturing and investment. By offering incentives and support for enterprises, the policy can encourage new investments,

EXPORT PREPAREDNESS INDEX

Uttar Pradesh ranked 4th in the report released by the Government of India (January 2026)

Ranked 1st among landlocked states

aerospace activities. Beyond attracting investment, the policy has wider economic significance. A growing defence and aerospace manufacturing base can generate skilled employment, support ancillary industries and create opportunities for MSMEs and technology-driven enterprises. By encouraging greater private-sector participation and innovation, the policy can contribute to building a more integrated industrial ecosystem

while supporting the broader national objective of strengthening domestic defence capabilities.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS OF THE POLICY

- DIC Land on lease at 1% rental for 10 years and 1.5% for 10+ years
- Land Subsidy @25% (DIC)
- Capital Subsidy @25–35%, up to max ₹500–₹1,000 crore over 5–15 years
- Logistics Subsidy up to ₹5 crore for importing Plant & Machinery and up to ₹25 crore (over 5 years) for exporting
- Green Infrastructure Capital Subsidy up to ₹1 crore (ETP/SLWM, etc)
- Marketing assistance up to ₹5–₹15 lakh for 5 years' participation at domestic/ international events
- Refund of patent filing and quality certification costs
- Skilling subsidy up to ₹2 lakh per year (up to 10,000 people)
- Grant for Skilling Centre/CoE/R&D Centre up to ₹10 crore

SECTORAL AND COUNTRY DESKS

Five sectoral desks established to attract new investments, promote priority sectors, and resolve investor issues quickly. Key sectors include: Textiles and Apparel, Automobile and Electric Mobility, Chemicals, Electronics, Global Capability Centers (GCC)

Country desks established for attracting FDI: Germany & France Desk, UAE & Singapore Desk, Japan Desk, South Korea Desk, Taiwan Desk, United Kingdom Desk

READER ENGAGEMENT INITIATIVE

Pervasive Dynamism

►► From Page 1

“At every step of the way, India gives me an injection of adrenaline that I rarely get in the West,” Italia said.

Such dynamism, according to Italia, is pervasive across the country, from big metropolises like Mumbai — which he compares to the vibrancy of New York City in the 1990s — to even smaller towns.

“That kind of energy is going to benefit the whole country,” he said. “Even in smaller cities like Chandigarh or Coimbatore, you detect elements of entrepreneurship within the society that you wouldn’t be able to get in the provinces of France, the provinces of Germany. And I believe that is at the heart of a society and an economy that will push towards growth.”

With India already returning the capital invested, Verlinvest is keen to crank up its play with investment plans of euro 1 billion over the next five years.

“We are getting more aggressive because India has done so well,” said Arjun Anand, Verlinvest’s Asia head. “We certainly see ourselves deploying euro 100-200 million a year in India. We go all the way from small companies in ventures to control deals.”

Sectors like health, fitness, live entertainment, digital content, sneakers are the next pockets of growth.

DATA REVOLUTION

A former PE executive who earned his stripes in Warburg Pincus, Italia was part of the team that backed Sunil Mittal’s Bharti Airtel in the mid 1990s, heralding the private equity boom in the country. Three decades later, he feels telecom players like Mukesh Ambani’s IPO-bound Jio Platforms are redrawing the consumption landscape once again.

From food retail to quick commerce, online travel to financial services, nearly every means of consumption gets channelled and amplified through digital “tools,” he said.

“People cannot live without mobile phones,” he said. “Such profound transformation wasn’t visible 30 years ago.”

India’s digital revolution made technology available to a wider population.

“We collect information, we disseminate information and with it we become protagonists of economic activity,” said Italia, a Parma born, Swiss resident. This transformation is also spawning new economic activities that are playing a pivotal role in the way Indians buy and spend and even engage socially.

“Think about being an influencer nowadays as a type of activity that did not exist a few years ago,” he said. “With bandwidth being available at unprecedented speed levels, telecom today has changed into a necessary element that helps one to relate to society altogether. And consumer spending is a byproduct of that.”

BRANDS TO SERVICES

With its roots in the alcobev industry — having marquee brands like Budweiser, Corona, Hoegaarden and Stella Artois — Verlinvest has been a very early investor in global beverage companies such as Vita Coco and Oatly that have grown substantially. In India, Sula was its first bet, which is now fully divested. Lahori (Zeera), Blue Tokai and Kopi Kenangan of Indonesia, Southeast Asia’s first unicorn in the food and beverage space, and

VitaminWater came later. More recently, the firm has started focusing on additional facets of consumer-facing businesses that went beyond brand pull, providing an experience or a service. Healthcare services, for example, is a key focus. Among others, it has invested \$75 million for a 20% stake in Eye Foundation, an ophthalmology chain, besides Red Sun, a senior care provider in China.

ACROSS THE CAP TABLE

The firm is flexible — from buying into growth and coming on board as a significant minority investor or even taking control like Epigamia or Ferty9, an IVF chain. The cheque sizes vary too — from \$1 million to \$100 million — either through venture arm V3 Ventures or Verlinvest itself.

Unlike several of listed PE peers that have to deploy capital only to raise more while also keeping a hawk’s eye on their share price, Verlinvest’s business model is “we have no obligation to deploy capital,” Italia said.

This allows the firm to hold onto an investment far longer and gives it more latitude to price assets.

“That has to be the name of the game for us, otherwise we are at the mercy of an abundant capital market and when there is abundance of capital, prices tend to escalate very quickly,” he said.

While giving the example of Veeba, a condiments and sauces company where the fund has been invested for a decade, patient capital also plays out in other ways.

“We can play the cycles a bit better,” Anand said. “As we have even experienced in India, some windows of time are just better for the capital markets than others and there are some windows where you wouldn’t want to really take a company public.”

‘Oligarchs’ Blocking Starlink’s Entry: Musk

They seek to maintain their monopoly, alleges SpaceX chief in an X post

Our Bureau

New Delhi: SpaceX CEO Elon Musk has accused unnamed “oligarchs” of blocking the US-headquartered satellite internet provider’s entry into India to protect their business interests, calling it a “crime against the people of India”.

“Unfortunately, we are being blocked by certain oligarchs in order to maintain their monopolistic chokehold on the Indian people,” Musk wrote in a post on X late Wednesday. “You can guess who they

are... This is a crime against the people of India.”

Musk’s comments come in the wake of remarks made by a senior SpaceX executive that Starlink is ready to launch services once it gets the remaining government approvals. Speaking at the India Mobile Congress (IMC), Lauren Dreyer, SpaceX’s vice president for Starlink business operations, said the company has built 20 gateway sites and hundreds of antennas in India, invested in infrastructure and adapted its operations to meet local security and regulatory requirements, including keeping Indian users’ data within the country.

“We built our Starlink operations specifically for India in recognition of Indian security requirements and other regulations, establishing controls of every layer for India, and keeping Indian user data within India...”



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“We built our Starlink operations specifically for India in recognition of Indian security requirements and other regulations, establishing controls of every layer for India, and keeping Indian user data within India...”

lator. But Starlink is not the only contender that is waiting for the final go-ahead: Bharti Group-backed Eutelsat OneWeb and Jio Satellite too are waiting for the security nod to start commercial satcom services. Both Eutelsat OneWeb and Jio Satellite have satcom permit and authorisation from the space regulator. In addition to security clearance, the three companies need spectrum for launching services, for which the government is likely to take a call soon on pricing.

Dreyer said Starlink’s management has been in regular touch with the authorities to sort out any differences. “Hopefully, next time I address the Congress, the government’s good work will have been complete and Starlink will be authorised and ready and reporting on stories here,” Dreyer said.

SC UPHOLDS MADRAS HC, INCOME TAX APPELLATE TRIBUNAL ORDERS

‘Electricity Subsidy that Doesn’t Create Capital Assets is Taxable’

Indu Bhan

New Delhi: An electricity subsidy that does not contribute to the creation of capital assets is a revenue receipt for the company that receives it and taxable under the Income Tax Act, the Supreme Court ruled on Wednesday.



The SC rejected Mepco Industries appeal that sought to treat the subsidy of ₹16.20 lakh as capital receipt

The subsidy does not lose its revenue character merely because, as a matter of business economics, reduction in electricity expenditure may leave more funds available with the assessee for its business, a bench comprising Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Shree Chandrasekhara said. The question is whether the government intended to make a contribution towards the capital structure or capital assets of an undertaking, the court said.

The top court upheld the Madras High Court and the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal’s orders that treated the subsidy received by Mepco Industries from the Pondicherry government as a revenue receipt and

included it in the taxable income.

The subsidy was given as an assistance in carrying on the business rather than as a contribution towards the capital outlay of the industrial undertaking, it said, adding that the subsidy was calculated with reference to the power charges.

The issue before the apex court was whether the electricity subsidy for the assessment year 1997-98 constituted a capital receipt, as claimed by the company, or a revenue receipt liable to tax under the Income Tax Act, 1961. While the compa-

ny said the 1975 subsidy scheme was intended to encourage the establishment of new industries in backward areas, the revenue authorities treated it as assistance towards the cost of power consumed in the course of the existing business.

The top court rejected the company’s appeal that sought to treat the subsidy of ₹16.20 lakh as capital receipt. The benefit in this case was calculated as a specified percentage of the actual energy charges and was available for a limited period commencing with production, and its immediate effect was to reduce the electricity cost incurred in the manufacturing process, it said.

The scheme did not require the subsidy to be applied towards acquisition of plant or machinery, construction of the factory, repayment of a capital borrowing, or creation of any other capital asset, the judgment stated. Thus the subsidy, being an assistance received after commencement of production to reduce the cost of electricity, was revenue in character, it said.

NCLT Approves 107 Resolutions in July-Sept Period

New Delhi: The insolvency tribunal NCLT approved 107 resolution plans involving an aggregate plan value of more than ₹11,000 crore in the September quarter of FY27, its highest-ever quarterly performance since its inception.

This was the ‘highest number of resolution plans approved in any quarter’ under the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP), the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) said in a statement. The tribunal had approved 60 resolution plans in the corresponding quarter of FY26, 57 in FY25, 82 in FY24, 47 in FY23, and 20 in FY22.

The NCLT was constituted on June 1, 2016, under the Companies Act, 2013, and became the adjudicating authority for corporate insolvency cases under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) from December 1, 2016.

Moreover, “the Tribunal has approved 185 resolution plans during the first half of FY 2026-27”, it said.

A total of 29 plans were approved by the Delhi bench and 35 by the Mumbai bench, while the rest were by others. —Our Bureau

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2	Steam Turbine and Generator with Auxiliaries	1) 80MW model, Single Cylinder, HP and LP 2) Generator: 105.5 MVA, 11.5 KV, 50 Hz
3	Heat Recovery Steam Generator (HRSG)	Horizontal unfired dual pressure, 2 drum, Natural Circulation boiler

Parties can visit the site and inspect the equipment and remaining packages with prior appointment. Sealed buying offer closing date - 31/10/2026. Contact: Email - samalkotbd220@gmail.com, Contact No. +91 9701307422

personal

LOST & FOUND

I, Atharv Sushil Mishra, have lost my original ICSE Class X Pass Certificate-cum-Statement of Marks for the 2025 examination, issued by CISCE, Unique ID/ Index Number: 8481619 School: Hiranandani Foundation School. The original document has been lost and may be treated as invalid if found.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Ardi Harsh Singh Avtar Singh S/O, Avtar Singh Arri R/O Room 14 Haji Chawl No 1 Jawahar Nagar Golibar Road Khar East Mumbai 400055 have changed my name to Harsh Singh Avtar Singh Arri for all purposes

I, Ms. Alka Narayan Kakade, daughter of Mr. Narayan Ramchandra Kakade, residing at Kurla Nehru Nagar, Mumbai and Married to Mr. Mahendra Tanaji Mane on 12th May 1993, have changed my name from Ms. Alka Narayan Kakade to Mrs. Sangeeta Mahendra Mane. I shall hereafter be known and called as Mrs. Sangeeta Mahendra Mane for all future purposes, vide affidavit dated 5th October 2026 sworn before Notary S.M.H. Zaidi.

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tender & notices

TENDERS

PanlIT Alumni Reach for Madhya Pradesh (PARAM) Foundation (MAPCET Office, 35 Shyamala Hills, Bhopal- 462002)

E-Tender Notice

E-Bids are invited for supply & installation of LPG Gas bank & Piping Works, Fabricated and Non-Fabricated commercial kitchen equipment, CCTV cameras, RO water purifiers, Hostel Kitchen Equipment, AMC of Genset, across multiple location in Madhya Pradesh

For detail, please visit the below mentioned link or Scan QR: <https://eprocurement.mjunction.in/EPBV2>

Web/org/PARAM/home.action

For Any queries please call: **M: 9897764001 / 9839651480 / 8806538043**

Zee Entertainment Faces MCA Probe Under Companies Act

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The ministry of corporate affairs (MCA) has initiated an investigation under Section 210 of the Companies Act into Zee Entertainment Enterprises (Zee), according to a regulatory filing by the company to the Bombay Stock Exchange.

Zee said it received a notice from the MCA on October 5 seeking certain information under Section 210(1)(a) and (c) in continuation of an ongoing inspection under Section 206(5) of the Companies Act. The company has not disclosed the subject matter of the investigation.

In the disclosure accompanying its filing, Zee described the nature of the action as “Investigation under Section 210(1)(a) & (c)” and the matter being called for as “Calling for information.”

The investigation is being handled by the MCA’s Office of the Regional Director, Western Region-II, in Mumbai, the filing said. Zee said it has already provided the information sought by the ministry and will provide further information and explanations as required. It said the action has no quantifiable financial impact at this stage.

Under Section 210, the central government can order an investigation into a company’s affairs, including where it considers an investigation necessary in the public interest. The provision also allows the government to appoint inspectors to investigate the company’s affairs and submit a report.

Zee had faced an MCA inspection in 2020 following the resignation of two independent directors, who had raised governance-related concerns. It is not clear from the latest filing whether the current Section 210 investigation relates to that earlier exercise or to subsequent matters.

Nazneen Ichhaporia, partner at law firm ANB Legal, said the action has been described as an investigation under Section 210(1)(a) and (c) of the Act.

These sections empower the central government to order an investigation into a company’s affairs if it considers one necessary, on receiving a report from the Registrar of Companies or an Inspector appointed under the Companies Act, or in the public interest.

“In my view, this disclosure should be read as a procedural development, not necessarily an adverse one at this stage. The MCA’s notice appears to be a follow-up to the ongoing inspection, where the regulator appears to still be gathering more information and not having reached any conclusive findings,” said Ichhaporia.

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

For and on behalf of the President of India, Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer (Co)/Kharagpur-721 301, S. E. Railway invites e-tender for the following works and will be opened at 12:00 hrs.: **Notice No.: ST-OT-DC-TRACK-HITACHI_26 Dtd: 05.10.2026; Description of works :** Provision of DC Track circuit for dual detection (Hitachi make E) in various station yards of Kharagpur division; **Tender value :** ₹ 9,78,55,589.24; **EMD :** ₹ 19,57,100.00; **Cost of tender document :** NIL; **Date of Opening :** 02/11/2026; **Completion Period :** 15 Months; **Date of Submission:** up to 12 hrs. of 02/11/2026; Interested Tenders may visit website www.iirps.gov.in for full details description specification of the tender and submit their bids online. In no case manual tenders for these works will be accepted. (PR-864)

CENTRAL RAILWAY

BHUSAWAL DIVISION

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

E-TENDER NOTICE No. BSL.N. S&T.29.2026-27 Date: 06.10.2026

Digitally Signed Online Open E-Tenders are invited from eligible Tenderers by Divisional Railway Manager (Signal & Telecom), Central Railway, Bhusawal for and on behalf of The President of India for the following work. **Name of work:** Various Telecom Works in connection with (i) Augmentation of existing SSE Signal store depot at Bhusawal (BSL) & Mannad (MMR) office and construction of new SSE office & store depot at Jalgaon (JL) on BSL division. (ii) Provision of Railnet connectivity at ROH Depot Bhusawal. (iii) Provision of telecom facilities at Admin Building ACL/BSL. (iv) Provision of internet connectivity at store shed/ACL/BSL (v) Development of Infrastructure and other needs of Railway school. **Approximate Cost :** Rs. 2,72,26,348.43 (Rupees Two Crore Seventy Two Lakh Twenty Six Thousand Three Hundred Forty Eight and Forty Three Paise Only); **Cost of Tender Form/Booklet:** Nil; **Earnest Money:** Rs. 5,44,500/- (Rupees Five Lakh Forty Four Thousand Five Hundred Only.); **Completion Period:** 6 Months after issuing of LOA.; **Bidding Start Date:** 14.10.2026; **Date & Time of Closing of Tender Submission:** 28.10.2026 15:00 Hrs.; **Date & Time of Opening of Tender:** 28/10/2026 15:30 Hrs (if possible); **Web site on which complete details of the Tender can be seen:** www.iirps.gov.in. **DE/05**

TRAVEL SAFELY, AVOID FOOTBOARD TRAVELLING

Diesel Equations Changing

►► From Page 1

September’s benchmark diesel prices were double those of a year ago, driven by refinery and shipping disruptions in West Asia and Russia. Tighter supplies and soaring prices have prompted China to ban diesel exports this month. The US administration was also under pressure to do the same before G7 countries agreed a few days ago to release more oil and diesel from storage to calm fuel prices.

Europe remains dependent on diesel imports, with the US and Saudi Arabia serving as key suppliers. “Recent refinery disruptions in Saudi Arabia, alongside already tight Russian product availability, further tightened the regional diesel balance. This created additional room for India to emerge as a swing supplier into Europe,” Dubey said.

A windfall tax on exports of diesel — about \$37 per barrel in September — erodes a significant portion of globally available margins for exporters. This tax, however, doesn’t apply to the export-only Jamnagar unit of Reliance Industries (RIL), the main exporter from India. RIL’s other refining unit, which primarily serves the domestic market, exports small volumes, as do Rosneft-backed Nayara Energy and some state-run refineries like Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals (MRPL).

RIL, Nayara Energy and MRPL also sell some volume to Indian Oil, Hindustan Petroleum and Bharat Petroleum for domestic retail sales. They do so at a price that is usually the international price minus the windfall tax.

Maharashtra Airport Development Company Ltd.

CIN: U45203MH2002SGC136979

TENDER NOTICE

MADC invites Tender for Appointment of Consultant for Preparation of Detailed Techno-Economic feasibility Study and Bid process management for development of Greenfield offshore International Airport at Kore, VadHAVAN Port Region in Palghar District, Maharashtra (Revised).

The detailed advertisement can be seen / downloaded from the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from **08/10/2026 14:00 hrs.**

Sd/-
Vice Chairman and Managing Director

GOVERNMENT OF HIMACHAL PRADESH

DEPARTMENT OF MPP & POWER

GLOBAL INVITATION OF BIDS FOR IMPLEMENTATION OF HYDRO ELECTRIC PROJECTS IN HIMACHAL PRADESH

2nd CORRIGENDUM OF NOTICE INVITING PROPOSALS

In partial modification of Notice Inviting Proposals (NIP) & 1st corrigendum for implementation of 27 Hydro Electric Projects (HEPs) upto 25 MW having total capacity of 300.9 MW published on 11.07.2026 & 06.09.2026, which is also uploaded in the Directorate of Energy website i.e. <https://doe.hp.gov.in/>, it is to inform that the last date of sale of Bid Documents, last date of submission of Bids and the date of opening of Bids are hereby extended under :

Last date for sale of Bid Documents : 27.10.2026 upto 1700 Hours
Tentative date of Pre-Bid Conference : 03.11.2026
Last date of submission of Bids : 17.11.2026 upto 1300 Hours (IST)
Date of opening of Bids : 17.11.2026 at 1500 Hours (IST) onwards

Note : If the Last date for submission of Bids or the date of opening of bids happens to be a holiday declared by the Government of Himachal Pradesh in Shimla, the Bids will be submitted and opened on the next working day in the same order and at the same time.

Payment of Bid Document Cost through RTGS/Online Banking:

Interested bidders may also purchase the Bid Document by making payment of the prescribed Bid Document cost through Online Banking/RTGS in the following bank account:

Account Number : 54140100009022
Bank : Bank of Baroda
IFSC : BARB0NEWSIM (Fifth character is zero)
Branch Name : NEWSIM, Himachal Pradesh
MICR Code : 171012004

Account Name : Chief Engineer Directorate of Energy, New Shimla

All other terms and conditions of the Notice Inviting Proposals published on 11.07.2026 shall remain unchanged.

For & on behalf of the Governor of HP
Sd/-
Director (Energy),
Directorate of Energy, Govt. of HP,
Tel. +91-177-2673552, Fax +91-1772673553
e-mail: ceenergy09@gmail.com

Advtr. No. : 1055/07/10/2026

BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

(HYDRAULIC ENGINEER'S DEPARTMENT)

e-TENDER NOTICE

The Commissioner of BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION invites online tender from the firms dealing in the line on item rate basis in three packet system for the work detailed below.

Department	Hydraulic Engineer
Section	Dy. Hydraulic Engineer (Maintenance)
Bid No	2026_MCGM_1343054
Subject	Work of Designing, Providing, Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of Safety Monitoring System of various location at Malabar Hill Reservoir under A.E.(M.)W.V.City-II section.
Bid Start Date & Time	08.10.2026 from 11:00AM
Bid End Date & Time	22.10.2026 till 16:00 PM
Website	http://mahatenders.gov.in
Contact Person	
a Name	V.V. Athawale
b Telephone	022-23073326 / 27 / 28
c Mobile No.	8087678061
d E-mail Id	aewwmcity02.he@mcmgm.gov.in

The tender document can be downloaded from the website (<http://mahatenders.gov.in>) By Order of the Municipal Commissioner of Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation.

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AVOID SELF MEDICATION

Houthis Strike Aden Airport as Proxy War in Yemen Flares Up

Saudi-led bloc intercepts missile near Riyadh; fighting over Bab el-Mandeb Strait intensifies

Yemen's Houthi attacked Aden's international airport with ballistic missiles and explosive-laden drones on Wednesday, the country's Transport Ministry said, as fighting between the Iran-aligned group and Saudi-backed government forces intensified.

Battles have focused in recent days on areas around the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a shipping route that has become more crucial for energy exports since the conflict between the US and Iran restricted trade through the Strait of Hormuz.

This week, Yemeni government forces with Saudi-led coalition air support launched a counter-offensive to recapture strategic territory near the strait and around the town of Mocha that the Houthis had captured in September, but it is unclear if their advance will hold.

The Houthis have repeatedly targeted infrastructure including airports, oil refineries and pipelines in Saudi Arabia, a US ally.

On Wednesday, the Saudi-led coalition forces said it had intercepted and destroyed a Houthi ballistic missile north of the Saudi capital Riyadh.

Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said in a statement that the group had targeted King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh with several drones. There was no immediate Saudi confirmation of an attack on the airport.

ad with several drones. There was no immediate Saudi confirmation of an attack on the airport.

BATTLE OVER BAB EL-MANDEB Any Houthi stranglehold on the Strait could threaten shipping or global oil flows, and Saudi Arabia has been seeking international assistance to repel the Houthis. Turkey is sending mainly defensive and technical support, two officials said on Wednesday.

Oil prices remained volatile amid the West Asia flare-up. Global Brent crude futures were trading at \$101.54 a barrel, up 96 cents at 11:06 a.m. ET (1506 GMT), while West Texas Intermediate futures were down 3 cents to \$89.41 a barrel.

Fighting on the western front remains concentrated in the Dhubbab district overlooking Bab el-Mandeb, with pro-government forces attempting an advance in the strategic hills to the east of that coastal plain, Yemeni military and government sources said.

On Monday the Yemeni government said it had reached Mocha, which sits at a junction with a supply route to the critical battleground of Taiz, but the claim had been premature, according to Yemeni military officials on the ground and analysts. **Agencies**



Houthi loyalists at a rally to recruit fighters in Sanaa on Wednesday | AFP

More than 200k People Displaced: UN



More than 200,000 people have been displaced from their homes since fighting in Yemen began in recent weeks, according to data released on Wednesday by the United Nations' International Organization for Migration.

IOM described the crisis sparked by renewed fighting between the Iran-backed Houthi group and Saudi-backed government

forces in Yemen as alarming, with displacement figures surging from 76,000 in mid-September to more than 200,000 as of Wednesday — nearly all of whom fled since fighting began in early September.

"People are running for their lives and finding nowhere safe to go," said IOM Director General Amy Pope, who called for more funding amid rising needs for food and shelter. **Reuters**

Trump Admin Weighs \$70k Fee for Int'l Students to Work in US

Another \$30k fee could be required for each renewal

The Department of Homeland Security on Wednesday proposed a \$70,000 fee for international students seeking to work in the United States, the latest effort from the Trump administration to crack down on foreign enrollment.

A proposed rule would require schools to pay the fee for every student who participates in the optional practice training programme, known as OPT, which allows students to work in jobs related to their major during or after their time in school. **Students are generally eligible for one year of work post-graduation, though certain science, technology, engineering and math majors are eligible for an additional two years.**

Schools would be required to pay the \$70,000 for each new student's initial application to the programme, and a \$30,000 fee for each renewal.

The change would represent a blow to American colleges and universities that heavily recruit stu-



Mortgage Rate Rises to Near 3-year High

The interest rate on the most common US home loan jumped last week to its highest in almost three years, worsening affordability for buyers. The average 30-year fixed-rate mortgage surged 19 basis points to 7.49% in the week ended October 2, the Mortgage Bankers Association said on Wednesday. It was last higher in November 2023. **It was last higher in November 2023. Reuters**

Moscow's Attacks on Ukraine Kill over 24

Russian missiles and drones pounded Kyiv and a dozen other Ukrainian regions overnight into Wednesday, killing at least 24 civilians, including four children, and wounding around 60 in Moscow's latest devastating barrage, Ukrainian officials said.

Three of the children killed when a Russian missile hit an apartment building were 1 year old and the other was 8 years old, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

Ukraine had anticipated the attack, with Zelenskyy warning the previous day that intelligence services had concluded that Russia was building up for a "massive" strike.

Although Ukraine knew about the looming attack, which coincided with Russian President Vladimir Putin's 74th birthday, it couldn't fend it off



completely.

The deaths and damage illustrated the difficulty Ukraine has in countering Russia's ballistic missiles and the new jet-powered drones used in Moscow's escalating bombardments. Without ammunition for Patriot air defense systems, Ukraine can't stop Russian ballistic weapons. It is racing to develop a new generation of interceptors fast enough to catch Moscow's jet-propelled drones. **AP**

\$200B Putin to Foot Record War Bill this Year



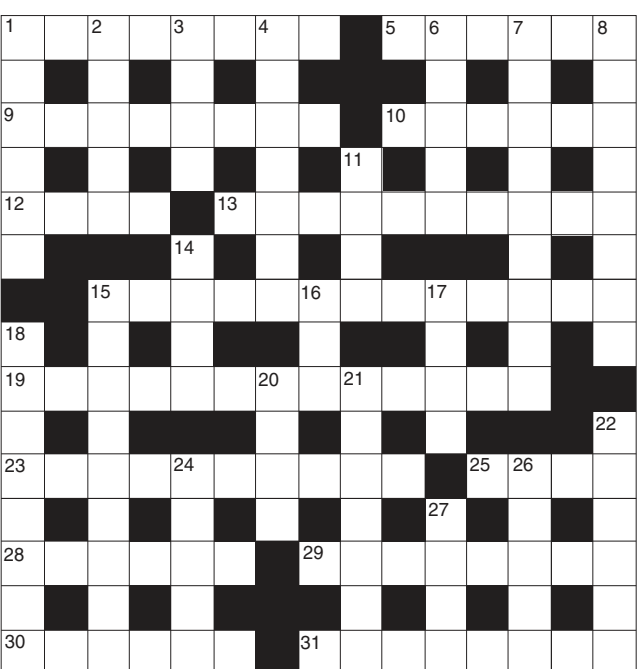
Russia's military spending is on track to hit a record this year after Vladimir Putin added almost \$60 billion to the outlays set out in the budget.

Global governments must act urgently to address challenges from an unbalanced AI boom, a prolonged energy shock and record debt piles, the International Monetary Fund said.

The rush to develop artificial intelligence is delivering a growth spurt that's so far confined to a handful of countries, Managing Director Kristalina Georgieva said Wednesday. Meantime the squeeze on key commodity suppliers due to conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine is set to continue into 2027, and soaring bond yields have left governments that amassed too much debt under mounting budget pressure, Georgieva said — calling advanced economies the "worst offenders" on the latter count. "The AI building boom is inflationary. The energy and food shocks are inflationary. Tariffs, defense spending, and high public debt can be inflationary," she said. **Bloomberg**

Advanced economies are 'worst offenders' in terms of piling up debt, says IMF's MD Kristalina Georgieva

Crossword



ACROSS
1 Man in gambling game showing aloofness (8)
5 Murmur recalling problem with book and article in French (6)
9 Food shop in sound year getting lovely (8)
10 Petty officer in minor quarrel has confidential information (3-3)
12 Extended note inserted in diary (4)
13 This person's stopping relation prepared for decisive sports contest (10)
15 Remove harmful stuff from meat contained in a suspect way (13)
19 Leading limo to move in due course (3,2,4,4)

23 Avoid conflict with quiet actress Claire after setback (5,3,2)
25 Writer swapping central parts shows liveliness (4)
28 Proprietors from Tyneside engaged in terrible rows (6)
29 One claim ruined industrial site (8)
30 Staggered in Scottish dance with last parts in the round (6)
31 Takes another's place and runs for election at home (6,2)

DOWN
1 Narrow pass ending in here in wild

field (6)
2 Sign of approval is held up in Lebanese city (5)
3 Graduate raised tips for literacy in a skilful way (4)
4 Curious sort with male Barcelona resident, for example (7)
6 Place to confer degree regarding workers' group (5)
7 Dealing in things that are bound to sell? (4,5)
8 Imposed objective to limit police (8)
11 Part of problem, maybe, for woman (4)
14 Almost inadequate medical examination (4)
15 Idling badly around European church? No, being industrious (9)
16 Proper conduct at salon regularly observed (3)
17 Wading bird seen among hibiscus (4)
18 Henry with quartet keeping hot for period of time (4-4)
20 Scot's sound of surprise over English line in darts (4)
21 Medic given work dismissed one not finishing studies (7)
22 Valuable material in end excited lady (6)
24 Figure evergreen, say, around hospital (5)
26 Miser settled in French city (5)
27 Female left a new pastry dish (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9723:
ACROSS: 6 Electric fields, 9 Overdo, 10 Freetown, 11 Engender, 13 Iconic, 15 Prompt, 17 Aglast, 19 Techie, 20 Enclaves, 22 Reclithe, 24 Recoup, 26 At one fell swoop.
DOWN: 1 Leaving present, 2 Gear, 3 Stroud, 4 Offering, 5 Cent, 7 Inform, 8 Down in the dumps, 12 Epoch, 14 Omaha, 16 Prettily, 18 Repeal, 21 Cerise, 23 Lana, 25 Crow.

EU Plans Import Caps on Chinese Hybrid Vehicles

The European Union is preparing so-called safeguard measures that would limit imports of Chinese hybrid vehicles into the bloc in a bid to reduce the trade deficit.

The European Commission, which handles trade matters for the EU, may impose the restrictions after Chinese-made hybrid sales surged in Europe, according to people familiar with the matter. They now make up a quarter of total sales, while the growth of imports of Chinese electric vehicles, which already face steep EU tariffs, has slowed.

The news sparked a rally in the shares of European automakers.

Safeguard measures allow the EU to restrict products from a sector if there's been a surge of imports into the bloc. One way the commission can enforce this is through the use of tariff-rate quotas, which place a levy on imports above a certain volume. The cap proposed by the EU would be time-limited, the people said. The commission plans to use hybrids as a test case, which, if successful, could be replicated with other sectors where the bloc sees trade imbalances, according to people in the know. **Bloomberg**

Student Protests: France Suspends Stun Grenade Use

The French government said on Wednesday it was pausing the use of stun grenades in its policing of student protests, after a 15-year-old boy's hand was blown off during a clash with riot police, fuelling protesters' accusations of police brutality.

Protests showed no sign of easing, with more than 500 schools closed a day after demonstrations swept across the country, and unions representing high-school students, teachers and other workers planning more marches for Thursday.

The wave of protests has been going on for more than two weeks and has exposed widespread public anger six months ahead of an election to replace President Emmanuel Macron.

At Lycee Lamartine, a high school in central Paris, protesters sang the Marseillaise, chanted slogans and performed Mexican waves as they blocked the entrance to the school. **Reuters**

'FlyDubai Co-Pilot Trained in the UK'

The FlyDubai co-pilot accused of attempting a murder-suicide mission on an Israel-bound flight trained to become a pilot at one of the UK's biggest flight schools, according to the Telegraph newspaper.

Hamam al-Hammami, 29, trained with L3 Airline Academy, a company that's now part of Acron Aviation, between 2018 and 2019 and received lessons at one or more centers in England, the Telegraph said.

Acron has said it will help with any investigation, according to the report. Authorities around the world, including in Australia and New Zealand, are piecing together al-Hammami's life before the alleged attack. He was enrolled at RMIT University in Melbourne between 2015 and 2017, but failed to complete an engineering qualification.

Al-Hammami was in New Zealand between November 2018 and May 2019 to undertake flight training for a UK-based company. **Bloomberg**

'Iran has Lost All Control of Hormuz'

Iran has "lost complete control" of the Strait of Hormuz, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Wednesday, adding that Tehran's economy was "in total and complete freefall".

"The Straits of Hormuz are open. There's almost as much oil flowing out now as there was before this conflict began. So they've lost complete control of the Straits," Rubio told reporters during a visit to Athens.

He argued that as a result of "crippling" sanctions, the Iranian economy was "about to reach a place few countries in the world

have been".

Every dollar received by the "radical Shia clerics" is spent on Hezbollah and Hamas, he said.

"Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon, simple, period, end of story," Rubio said.

"And anything they agree to that would be acceptable to the United States has to be something that ensures that Iran will never have a nuclear weapon."

Separately, Rubio said the western world must embrace "national power" and technological innovation or risk sliding into decline.

His speech is expected to be packed with praise for ancient heroes such as Alexander the Great, follows an address in February where he argued that Europe was threatened by mass immigration and called for it to defend Christian civilisation. **AFP**

AI + OIL + DEBT IMF Chief Flags Cocktail of Risk

Global governments must act urgently to address challenges from an unbalanced AI boom, a prolonged energy shock and record debt piles, the International Monetary Fund said.

The rush to develop artificial intelligence is delivering a growth spurt that's so far confined to a handful of countries, Managing Director Kristalina Georgieva said Wednesday. Meantime the squeeze on key commodity suppliers due to conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine is set to continue into 2027, and soaring bond yields have left governments that amassed too much debt under mounting budget pressure, Georgieva said — calling advanced economies the "worst offenders" on the latter count. "The AI building boom is inflationary. The energy and food shocks are inflationary. Tariffs, defense spending, and high public debt can be inflationary," she said. **Bloomberg**

Advanced economies are 'worst offenders' in terms of piling up debt, says IMF's MD Kristalina Georgieva

NOBEL PRIZE: CHEMISTRY

Duo Lauded for Solving 'Mirror Image' Mystery

Henri B. Kagan and Kenso Soai won the Nobel Prize in chemistry Wednesday for their efforts to resolve mysterious mirror images in chemical molecules, a discovery that transformed modern medicine.

Many molecules of life come in versions that look alike but aren't exactly identical, like right and left hands. One mirror image of the chemical carvone smells like mint, for example, while the other has a whiff of caraway.

When designing drugs to treat diseases, scientists want to be choosy about which mirror image they're getting. They want the version of a molecule that'll treat a cold, not the kind that'll make the snifflers worse.

Kagan and Soai found ways to make chemistry pick a side, de-



Above: Kenso Soai; Below: Henri B. Kagan

signing and manipulating reactions to produce the desired mirror image.

"This is probably the coolest experiment in organic chemistry," said Peter Somfai, a member of the Nobel Committee for Chemistry. "Taken together, the groundbreaking discoveries by Henri Kagan and Kenso Soai have reshaped our understanding of molecular chirality — how it is created, amplified and

transmitted."

Scientists paid tribute to Kagan and Soai's groundbreaking work, which the Nobel committee described as a feat never previously achieved by anyone "other than life itself." **AP**

AI RESHAPES GLOBAL MKTS

Taiwan Goes Past S Korea at Top

As investors enter the final stretch of a year that's propelled South Korea and Taiwan to the forefront of AI trade, the latter is emerging as the stronger bet. The Taiex Index beat the Kospi by about 23 percentage points last quarter; the widest margin

since the turn of the century. Earnings upgrades also outpaced those for its Korean peer for the first time since March 2025. About 40% of fund managers surveyed by BoA last month said they were overweight Taiwan, versus 25% for Korea. **Bloomberg**

NON-SEQUITUR



KREMLIN BLAMES MEDIA

WHO Pushes for Details on Plague Worker's Death

The World Health Organization said on Wednesday it had asked Russia for more information about what killed a plague institute worker in Siberia, but the Kremlin said Moscow had shared what it knew and accused the media of spreading lies.

Russian authorities say the 28-year-old laboratory worker died on Friday from pneumonia of an as-yet unestablished origin, in a case that has prompted international concern, including from US President Donald Trump, and which saw around 200 people initially placed in quarantine.

Russia's health watchdog said on Tuesday that no cases of plague had been detected among anyone who had come into contact with the deceased worker, Darya Shipilova, and a local official said that 60% of those placed in quarantine had been released.

But Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, the director general of the WHO in Geneva, said in a statement on X that his organisation needed more information from Russia to fully understand what had happened.

"WHO has requested further information to clarify the cause of the severe pneumonia, the pathogen that prompted the public health measures, and media reports of a second employee with pneumonia of undetermined cause," he said.

"Timely, complete and transparent information sharing under the International Health Regulations is essential to clarify conflicting reports and enable an accurate assessment of potential public health risks."

The Kremlin said Russia had properly informed the WHO about the incident in line with established procedures. **Reuters**

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 39 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.

www.hidato.com

Difficulty: ★☆☆☆☆

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

49	53	54	55	56	57	58	2
50	48	52	62	61	60	59	3
47	51			63	64	65	5
44	46			35	66	67	6
45	43	37	36	33	34	71	68
42	40	38	32			72	70
41	39	31	73			73	74
28	29	30	69	78	77	76	75
27	24						15
26	25	23	22	21	20	19	18
25	23	22	21	20	19	18	17

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7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 social media metric (7)	
2 in disbelief (6)	
3 fair share between partners (4)	
4 hassled from the audience (7)	
5 tow trucks (8)	
6 splits (up) (7)	
7 Shirley on the drinks menu (6)	

VVI	HA	FO	LF	OWS
AG	RS	ST	CKL	CKE
HA	ES	ED	LL	MP
TE	LE	DI	WRE	HE

Yesterday's Answers: 1. BLUEBERRIES 2. HUGH 3. DREAMER 4. HIGHTAILS 5. PERSPIRED 6. CURRIES 7. COKE

ET

CORNER OFFICE CONVERSATION



Adaption's Sudip Roy on Rethinking How AI Models Are Built

Sudip Roy talks to ET's **Swathi Moorthy** about why the next phase of AI may be less about building ever-larger models and more about adaptation, efficiency, and solving specific enterprise problems.

Also available on [EconomicTimes.com/podcast](#), [Amazon Prime Music](#), [Apple Podcasts](#), [JioSaavn](#) and [Spotify](#).

TCS may Post Modest Q2 Revenue Growth as Delays Cloud Projects

IT bellwether to continue June quarter trend, which dims recovery hopes for the full year

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) is expected to show a marginal sequential uptick in dollar denominated revenue for the September quarter after reporting a flat performance in the previous quarter. A sustained delay in project ramp ups amid slower decision-making by clients will likely restrain the top line performance of the country's largest software exporter. Revenue is expected to grow by a modest 0.5% to \$7,665 million from the quarter ago, according to the average of the estimates by ETIG and 10 brokerages. TCS is slated to declare the quarterly performance on Thursday after trading hours. "We reckon TCS shall deliver +0.6% sequential constant currency revenue growth and +0.5% dollar denominated revenue growth," mentioned Nu-

Slow & Steady

Top IT September'26 Quarter Estimates

	REVENUE				NET PROFIT	
	\$ MILLION	QOQ % CHANGE	₹ CRORE	QOQ % CHANGE	₹ CRORE	QOQ % CHANGE
TCS	7,660.3	0.5	73,132	1.2	13,841	-0.1
Infosys	5,149.2	1.3	49,170	2.0	7,994	2.9
HCL Tech	3,731.0	2.2	35,610	3.0	4,866	5.2
Wipro	2,596.0	-0.7	24,857	1.2	3,473	3.5
Tech Mahindra	1,683.1	1.4	16,063	2.2	1,699	15.9*
Top Five Total	20,819.6	0.9	198,832	1.8	31,873	2.6

*Low base in the previous quarter.
Source: Average of estimates by ETIG and 10 brokerages

ma Wealth Management in a pre-view report, adding that the growth will be affected by a slower-than-expected pickup in the second half of the quarter amid heightened geopolitical uncertainty. A subdued performance in the

first two quarters of the current fiscal year, which traditionally represents a strong period for Indian software exporters, reduces hopes of a recovery in the remainder of the year given seasonal weakness in the third quarter due to furloughs and slow project ramp ups in the fourth quarter as

clients finalise IT budgets. The rupee denominated revenue is expected to grow at a marginally higher rate of 1.2% to ₹73,171 crore, helped by a 1% sequential depreciation in the average rupee rate against the dollar during the quarter. Net profit is likely to grow by a tad 0.4% to ₹13,899.6 crore while operating margin may expand by 20-40 basis points from the previous quarter's level of 24% in the absence of a salary increase. The company is expected to book new orders worth \$8 billion-10 billion during the quarter. The management's commentary on demand trend, client spends, progress on the initiatives pertaining to artificial intelligence (AI) and its impact on the traditional revenue model and hiring trends will be crucial. The stock has remained range-bound over the past three months, trading at a trailing price-earnings multiple of 14 compared with a five-year average multiple of 21.

Earnings Preview

SPREAD ACROSS OVER 400 ACRES IN SIX METRO CLUSTERS

Brookfield Buys ESR's 10.5 m sq ft Logistics Portfolio for ₹4,300 cr

Global firm widens India realty footprint into industrial and logistics segment

Kaillash Babar

Mumbai: Global alternative investment major Brookfield has acquired a 10.5 million sq ft logistics portfolio from ESR India, committing ₹4,300 crore, or \$450 million, towards the transaction and future development of the portfolio, marking its entry into India's industrial and logistics real estate market. Brookfield has acquired a 100% interest in the portfolio, while ESR will continue to manage the properties in the near term. Spread across more than 400 acres in six metro clusters, the portfolio comprises eight Grade A parks across major gateway cities including Mumbai, Pune, Delhi

NCR, Chennai and Kolkata. The operating portfolio is 98% leased and caters to a diversified mix of logistics and industrial occupiers. ET was the first to report in October 2025 that Brookfield had emerged as the highest bidder for the logistics assets portfolio spread across India. "As India's integration into global supply chains accelerates, high-quality logistics infrastructure will enhance the country's logistics capabilities and cost competitiveness. We remain well-positioned to partner with governments, global institutions and corporations to deliver solutions at scale, strengthening supply chains, enhancing connectivity, providing accommodation solutions for industrial workforce and supporting the country's economic ambitions," said Ankur Gupta, deputy chief investment officer and head

of Asia Pacific and Middle East, real estate at Brookfield. Developed and managed by ESR, the assets are located along industrial and freight corridors close to key manufacturing and warehousing hubs. The portfolio includes light manufacturing facilities, fulfilment centres and warehouses, providing Brookfield with immediate scale across some of India's leading industrial and logistics markets. "ESR will continue to manage the portfolio, providing continuity for customers while supporting its next phase of growth. This realisation for our capital partners reinforces our conviction in the country's long-term growth prospects, supported by strong economic fundamentals, an expanding manufacturing base and its growing role as a global supply chain hub," said Abhijit Malkani, CEO-India at ESR. The acquisition builds on Brookfield and ESR's relationship across Asia Pacific and expands Brookfield's India real estate exposure.

NBCC Floats ₹9.6k-cr Tenders for Stalled Supertech Projects

New Delhi: In a major relief for homebuyers of 16 stalled housing projects by bankrupt builder Supertech, NBCC (India) has floated 25 tenders for ₹9,620.33 crore for construction and related works across the project portfolio. NBCC was appointed as the project management consultant for completion of these projects by the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal in December 2024, but there has been no progress since then. The 16 projects, spread across Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Uttarakhand and Karnataka, comprise nearly 50,962 stalled housing units, of which 39,870 were sold. Of the homes that were sold, 24,871 were handed over to buyers, while 14,999 have yet to be delivered. The Supreme Court in February upheld NBCC's mandate, providing the legal certainty needed to implement the completion plan. Completion of work on the sold apartments requires an investment of ₹1,700 crore. Receivables from these units are estimated to be ₹2,200 crore.—**Faizan Haidar**

GROWING ASIA FOOTPRINT

CoreWeave Stitches AdaniConneX Deal for Data Centres in India

Bloomberg

AI cloud-computing provider CoreWeave Inc is continuing an expansion in Asia with its first data centres in India, part of a venture involving conglomerate Adani Group. CoreWeave will use 240 megawatts of capacity at AdaniConneX's Talaja campus in Navi Mumbai, with an option to double that amount, the company said in a statement Wednesday. AdaniConneX is a joint venture of Adani Group and EdgeConneX. CoreWeave is also setting up an office in India. The investment is expected to total in the multiple billions of dollars over the lifetime of the project, with the first data centres slated to come online in mid-2028. CoreWeave, based in Livingston, New Jersey, has been expanding geographically in order to boost available capacity and better serve global customers. In August, it announced its first foray into Asia with projects in Indonesia. The company said that month that it had about 4.2 gigawatts' worth of contracted power—roughly equivalent to the out-

put of four nuclear reactors. But with demand remaining high, chief executive officer Mike Intrator said last month that the company is "largely sold out" of capacity. Energy availability, measured in megawatts or gigawatts, is the most common benchmark for data centre capacity because securing power is usually the biggest factor. CoreWeave will equip the Indian data centers with Nvidia Corp's latest Vera Rubin chips for use in tasks like training and running models, handling reasoning, and powering AI agents. AdaniConneX is also one of the companies working on a massive India data centre project for Alphabet Inc's Google. Data centre capacity in India, particularly that designed for AI tasks is growing rapidly. After building roughly 2.2 gigawatts of operational capacity over the past three decades, India is expected to reach 12 gigawatts by 2030, according to a July report by Wood Mackenzie. AI-specific capacity alone is projected to jump almost 24-fold to 6.5 gigawatts.

CoreWeave to use 240 MW at AdaniConneX's Talaja campus, with an option to double the capacity

CARE Ratings Upgrades Adani Enterprises to 'AA'

Our Bureau

Mumbai: CARE Ratings has upgraded its long-term rating for Adani Enterprises (AEL) to 'AA' from 'AA-', while retaining a 'stable' outlook for the flagship company of the Adani Group. This is the highest rating the company has ever received. The upgrade by CARE reflects Adani Enterprises' improved financial flexibility, following a ₹15,000-crore qualified institutional placement in July, and a 5.5% stakesale in its subsidiary Adani Airports Holding at a pre-money valuation of ₹1.67 lakh crore. "Rating upgrade also factors in likely expansion of profit before

interest, lease, depreciation and tax of AEL in FY27 supported by stabilisation of operations at Kutch Copper, continued growth in non-aero revenue across airports and commencement and progressive ramp-up of operations at Navi Mumbai International Airport," the rating agency said on Wednesday. Adani Enterprises houses the incubating businesses of the Adani Group including airports, data centre, defence and aerospace, mining services, and the road, metro and rail businesses. It previously incubated the ports, thermal, renewable power generation, power transmission, and city gas distribution businesses.

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